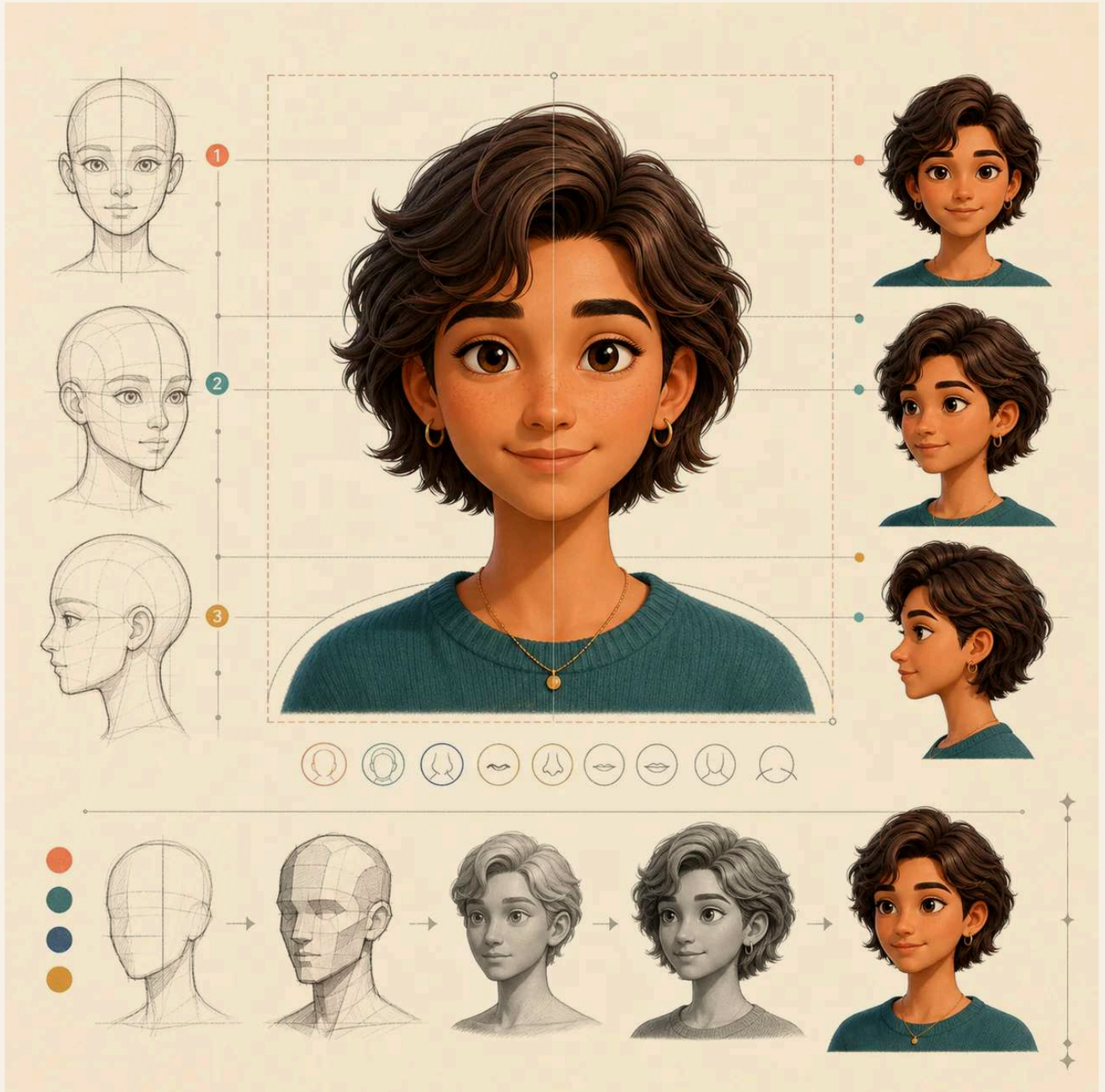


Palari

The Character Design Handbook



A shared visual world

Built from individual faces.

Palari is a warm, optimistic portrait language between animation character design and editorial portraiture. This first edition turns the visual system into a practical, inclusive guide.

Contents

Ten chapters from first shape to final production.

01	Palari DNA	5–10
02	People, not presets	11–20
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Read in sequence, or use the chapter rail as a studio reference while designing, reviewing, modeling, or masking a portrait.

Consistency without sameness

The Palari inclusion charter

Palari characters represent individuals, not regional or demographic presets. Human features overlap across populations; references guide design, assumptions do not.

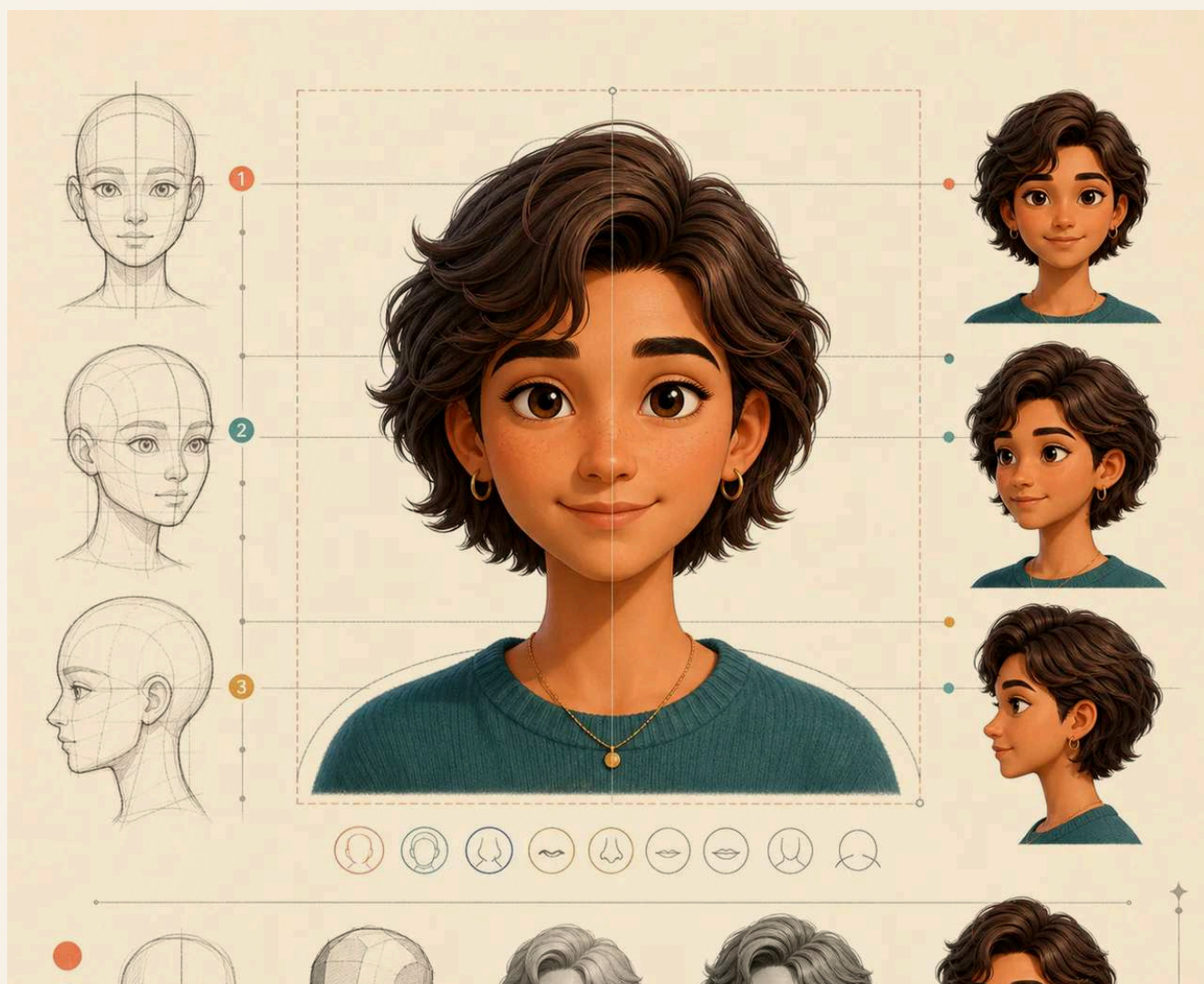
- Observe the individual instead of selecting a demographic template.
- Vary anatomy—not merely skin color, hair, or accessories.
- Never infer ethnicity, nationality, religion, or identity from appearance.
- Show the same emotional range across visibly different faces.
- Research cultural clothing and headwear with multiple precise references.



01

Palari DNA

Recognizable as one world. Memorable as one person.

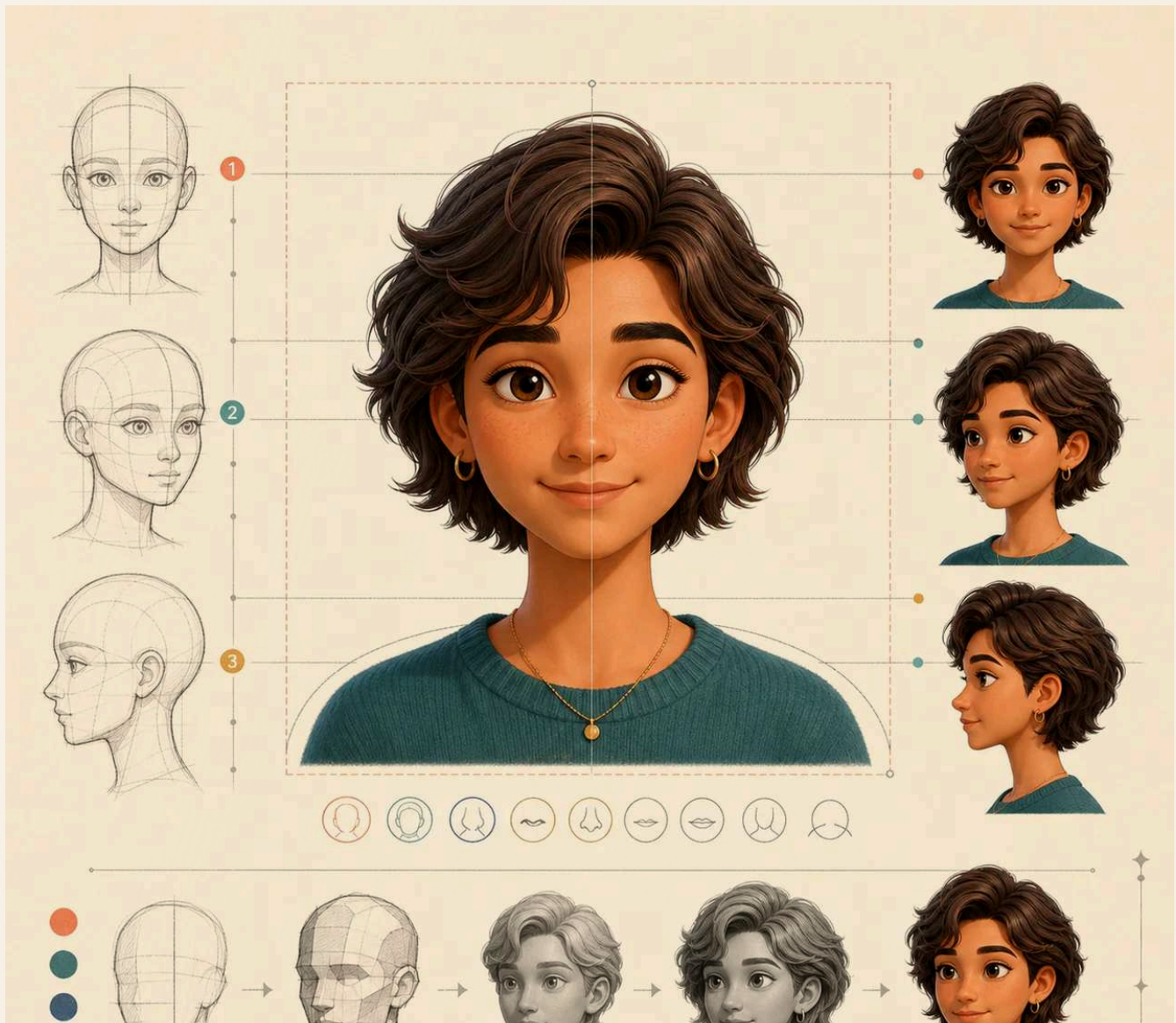


Begin with the frame

The square portrait is a designed stage.

Work at eye level. Keep the complete hair or head covering, full neck, both shoulders, and enough upper chest to ground the portrait. The shoulder arc stabilizes the composition.

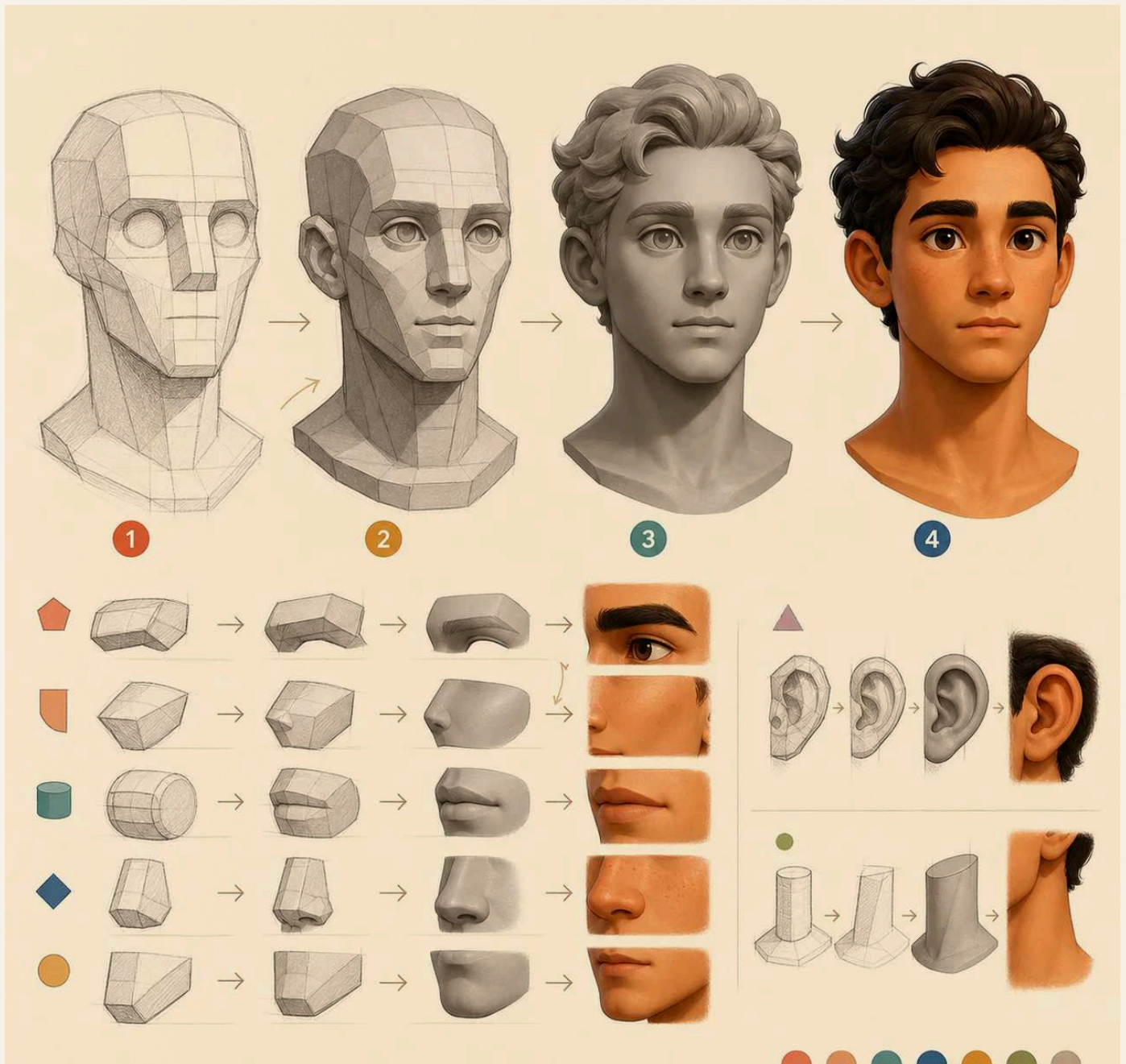
- Square 1:1 frame
- Restrained front or three-quarter view
- Complete head and shoulders
- Approachable camera height



Skull before styling

Construction carries identity before hair, color, or accessories arrive.

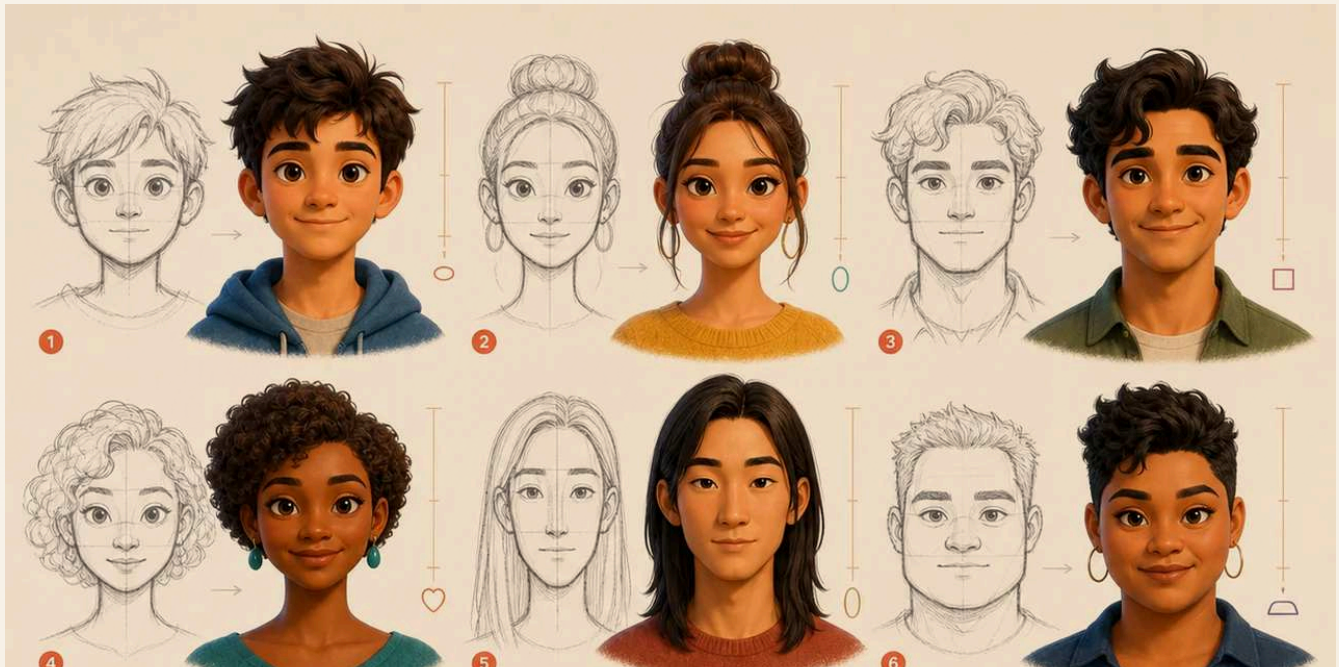
Build the cranium, muzzle, jaw, neck, and ears first. A Palari is simplified, not flat: broad planes remain believable beneath the polished surface.



Shape language

Soft geometry with a clear silhouette.

- Generous cranium
- Designed jaw rhythm
- Readable cheek volume
- Neck with believable weight
- Subtle asymmetry



Avatar 002



Avatar 003



Avatar 009

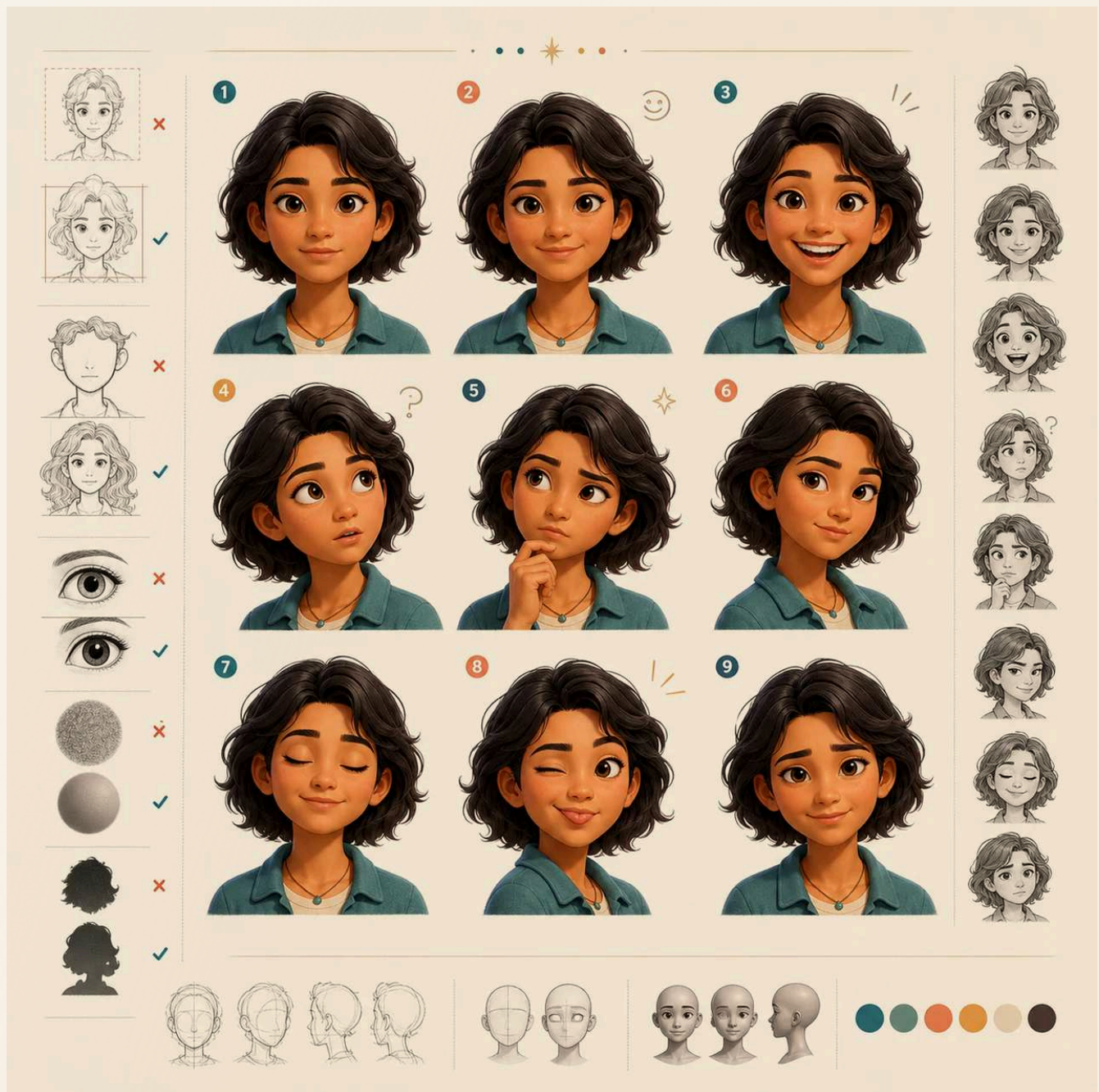


Avatar 146

Large shapes win

Detail should clarify, never compete.

Check the portrait as a thumbnail before inspecting eyelashes, knit grain, or flyaways. If the silhouette, gaze, and shoulder base do not read at small size, detail will not repair them.



DNA checkpoint

Approve the foundation before moving to features.

- Identity reads without color
- Eyes sit in believable sockets
- Head and shoulders are complete
- Expression is warm but not generic
- Large value groups stay separated



Avatar 001



Avatar 004



Avatar 144



Avatar 148

People, not presets

Observation is more specific than assumption.



Six constructions

Six faces begin with six different structural relationships.

Compare eyelid structure, eye spacing, brow rhythm, bridge height, tip shape, cheek volume, jaw width, and age. None of these observations defines a population.

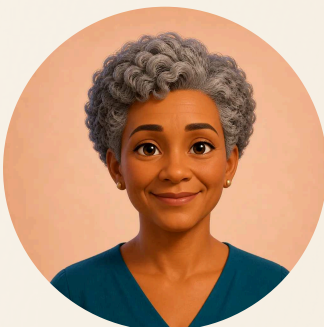


Variation overlaps

A feature never tells the whole story.

Human traits are continuous and overlapping. Design a complete individual from several observed relationships rather than assembling a regional checklist.

- Use multiple references
- Look for relationships, not labels
- Avoid a single default skull
- Let features vary independently



Avatar 145



Avatar 147



Avatar 151

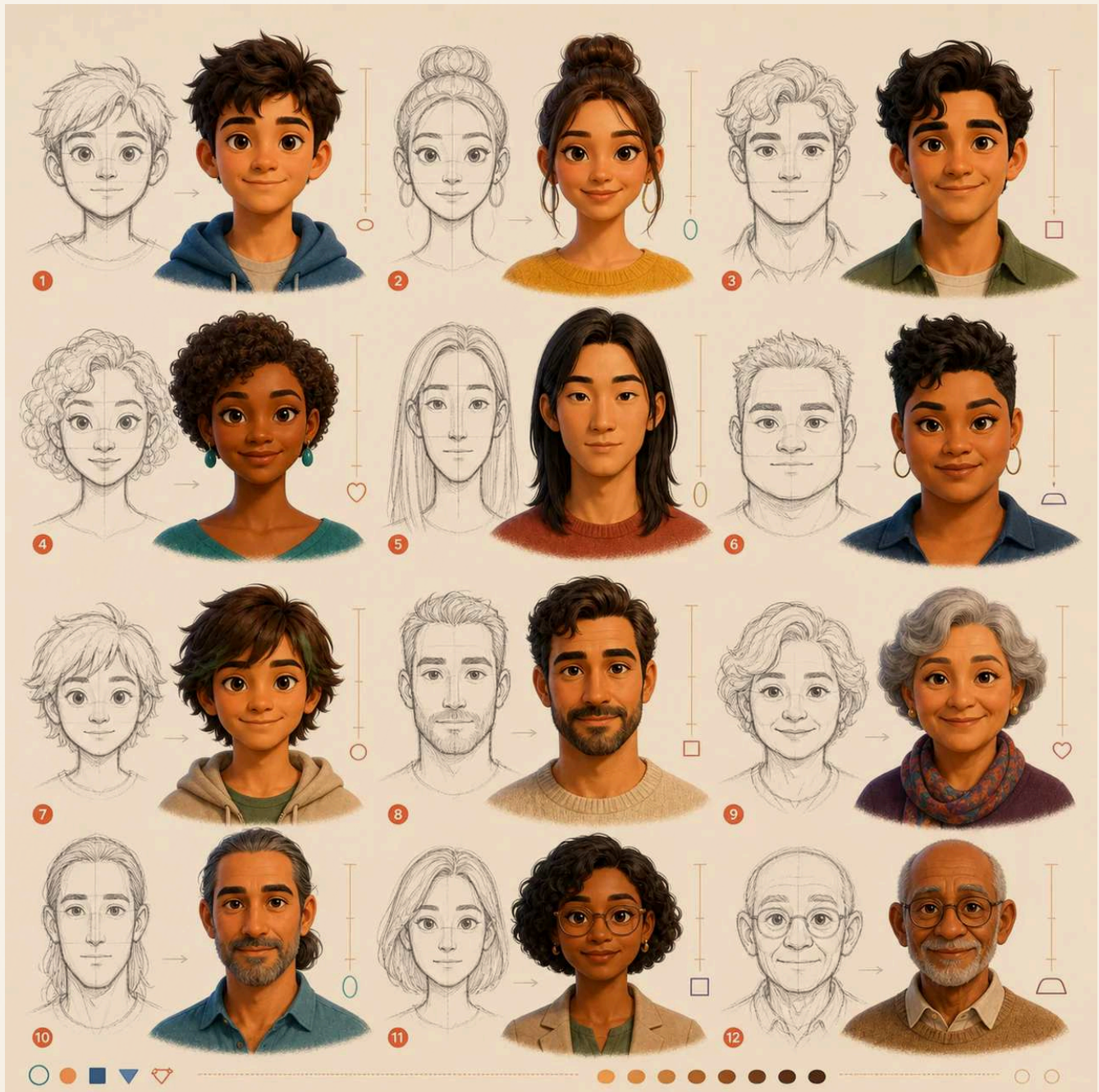


Avatar 154

Beyond a recolored default

Diversity begins in construction.

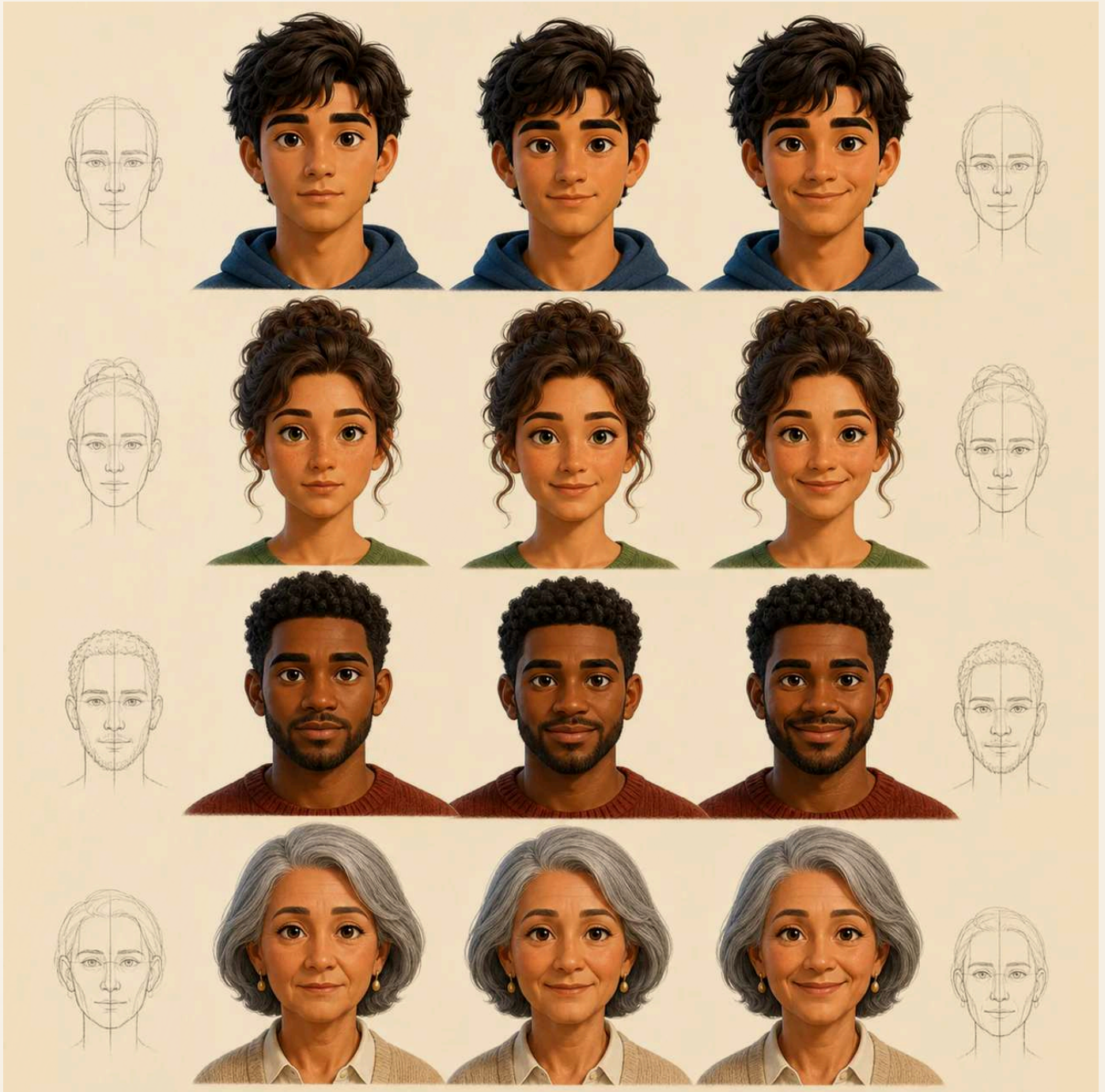
Changing only surface color leaves the same face underneath.
Change the cranium, jaw, cheeks, feature spacing, eyelids,
nose, mouth, age, and silhouette with equal care.



Shared emotion

Emotion is shared. Anatomy remains individual.

Across different faces, a gentle smile still coordinates lids, brows, cheeks, lips, and jaw. Preserve every person's structure while the expression changes.



Expression is not geography

Do not assign emotional behavior to a region or ethnicity.

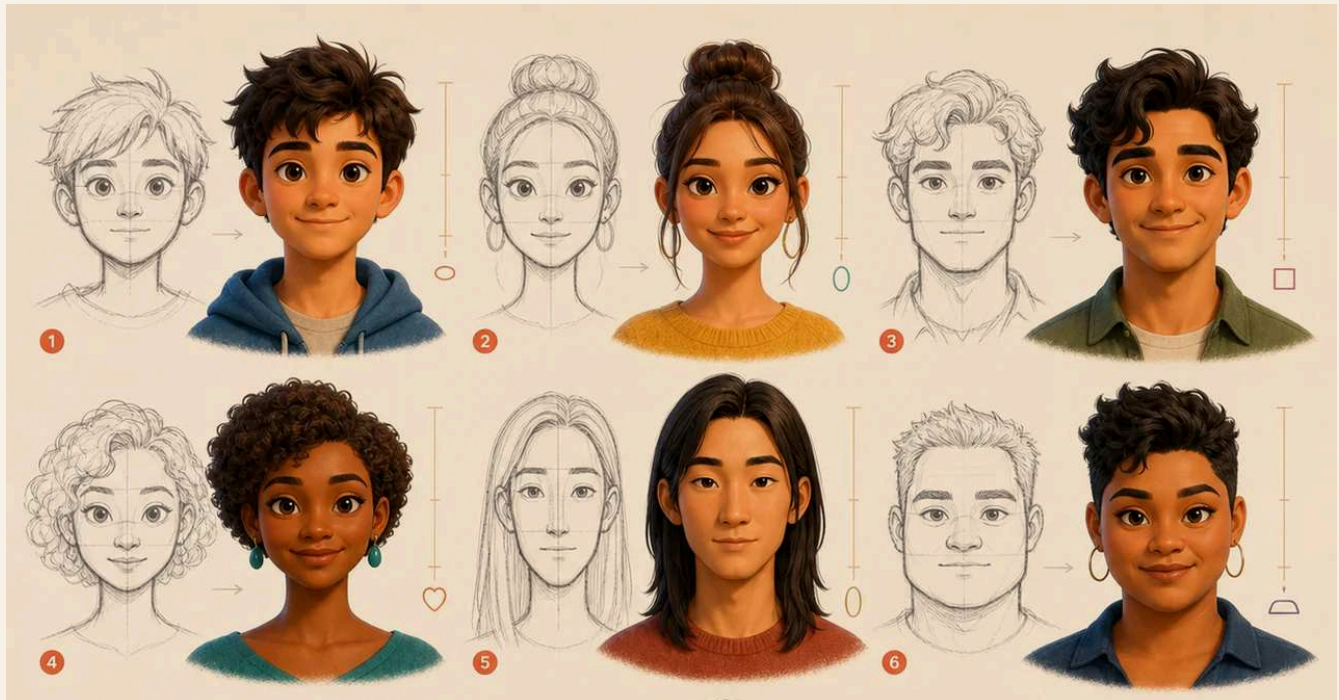
Culture may shape context, gesture, or storytelling, but this handbook never treats expression as regional anatomy. Give every face access to the same nuanced emotional range.

- Start from neutral
- Track coordinated muscle changes
- Preserve identity
- Avoid caricature

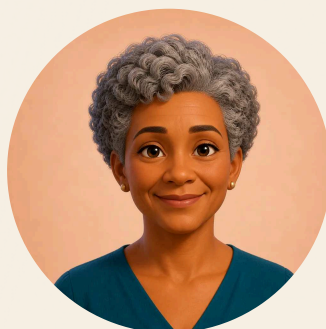
Age is structural

Age changes proportion, planes, posture, and material response.

Avoid reducing age to wrinkle symbols. Study eyelid weight, cheek support, mouth volume, jaw transition, hair character, and the way soft light travels across the face.



Avatar 144



Avatar 145



Avatar 146

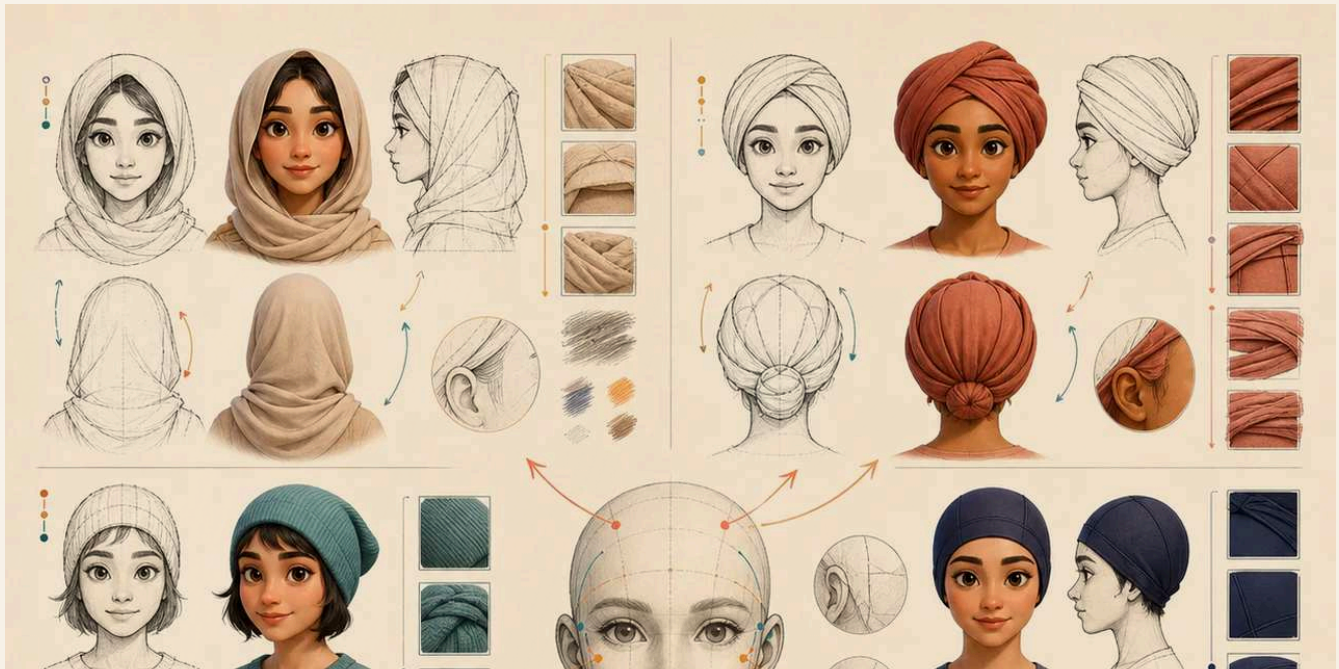


Avatar 147

Cultural specificity

Respect starts with precise reference.

A hijab, turban, braid pattern, garment, or piece of jewelry is not generic decoration. Research construction, material, wrapping logic, and context with more than one source.



Avatar 001



Avatar 150



Avatar 155

Labels describe the artwork

They do not define a person.

Internal coverage labels help find visual gaps. They are not demographic truth and must never be exposed as claims about ethnicity, nationality, religion, gender identity, or exact age.



Avatar 148



Avatar 152



Avatar 153



Avatar 157

Inclusion checkpoint

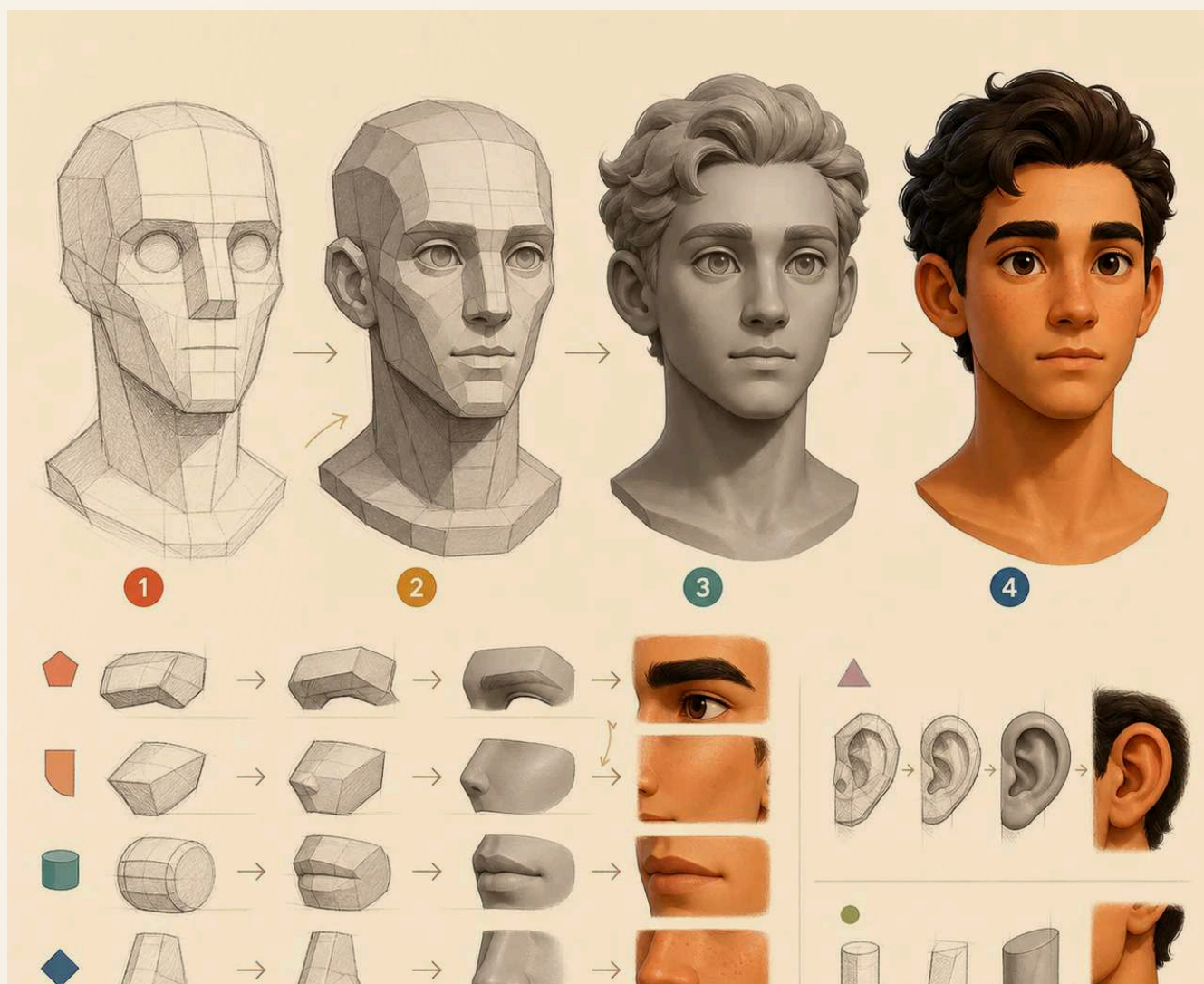
Reference beats assumption.

- Every face has a distinct construction
- No region is reduced to one look
- Skin tone is not the only variation
- Expressions remain available to everyone
- Cultural elements use precise references
- Captions avoid inferred identity



Head construction

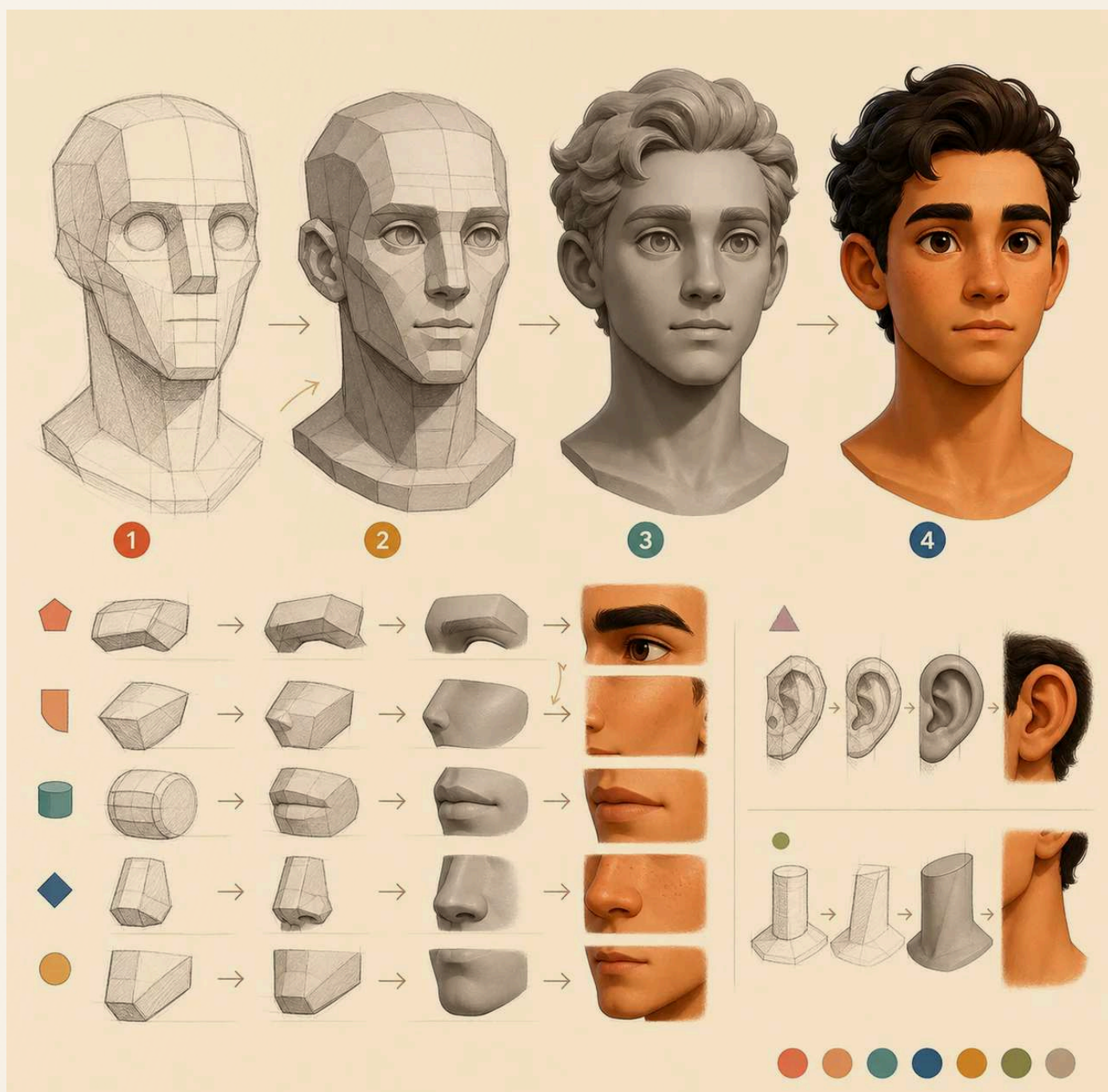
Build the volume that styling will reveal.



Cranium, muzzle, jaw

Three interlocking masses establish the head.

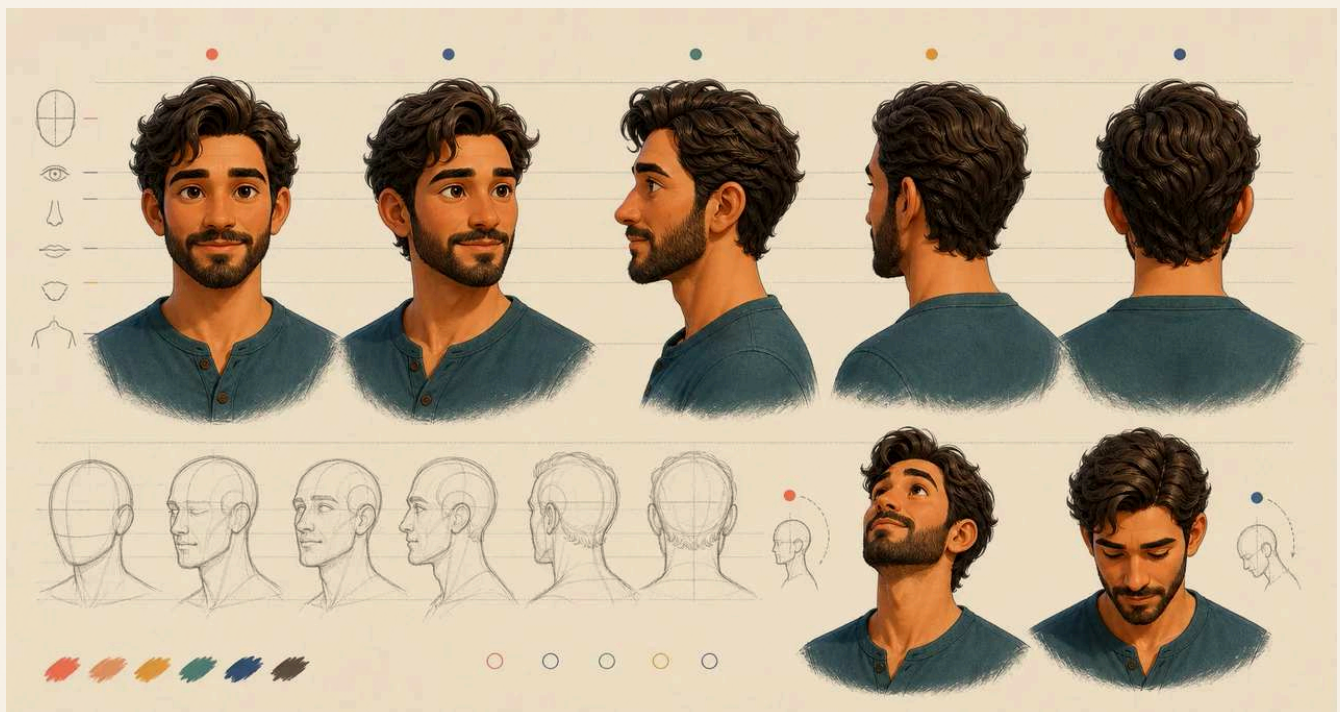
Block a generous cranium, a soft mouth barrel, and a designed jaw before smoothing transitions. The neck enters beneath the skull as a supporting cylinder, not a narrow peg.



Landmarks travel together

Brows, eyes, nose, mouth, and chin wrap around one volume.

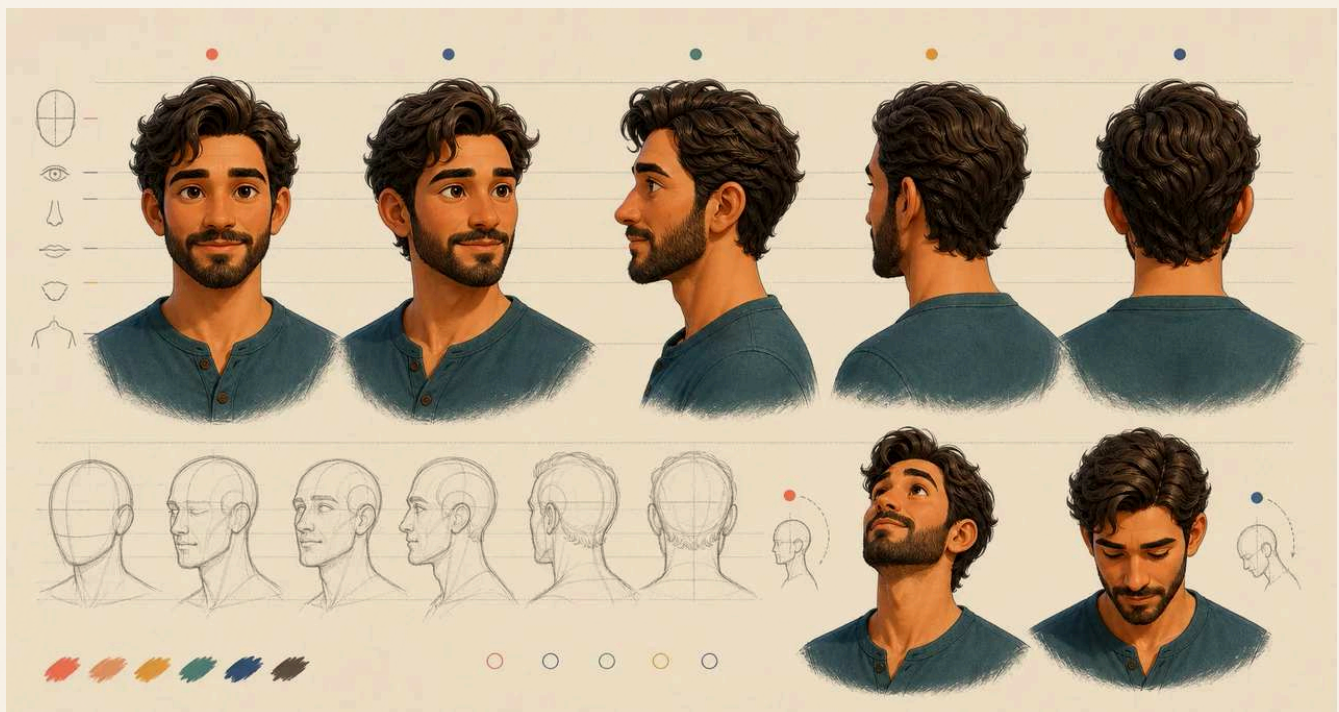
- Brow ridge
- Eye line
- Nose base
- Mouth barrel
- Chin
- Ear placement



Front to three-quarter

Turn the head; do not slide the features.

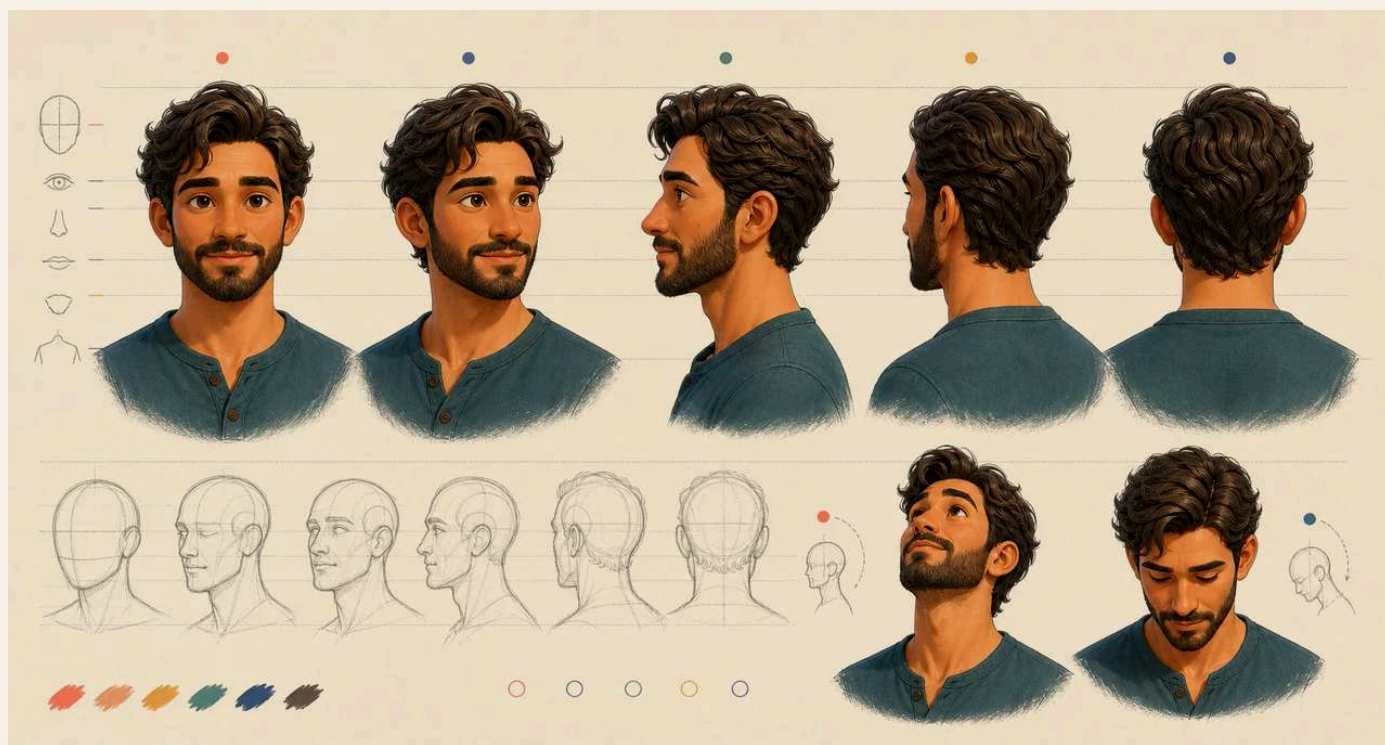
The far eye narrows, the nose overlaps, the mouth wraps, and the jaw silhouette changes. Preserve skull width and feature spacing through the turn.



The profile test

One silhouette reveals many construction errors.

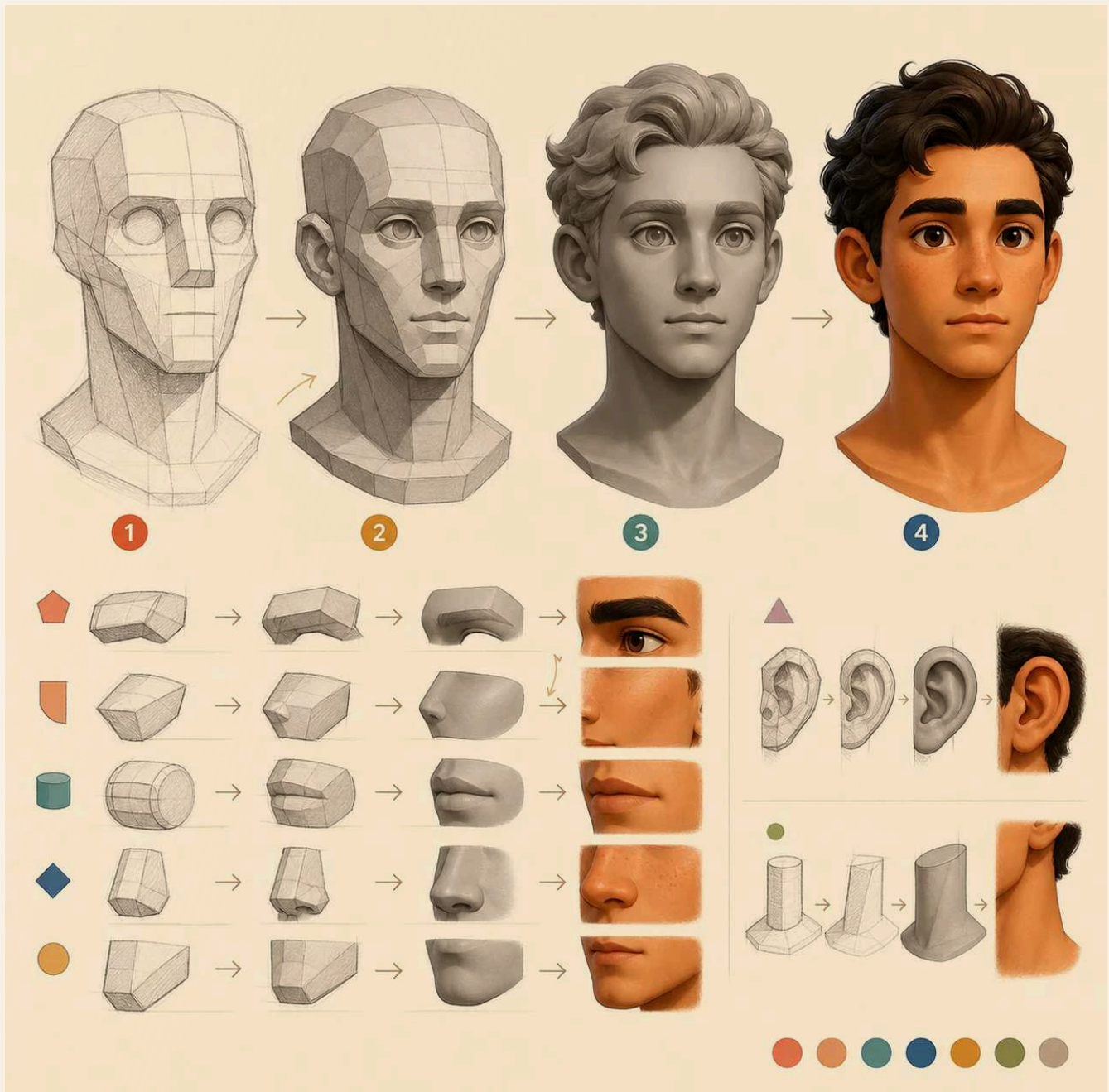
Seat the eye in its socket. Design the forehead, nose, lips, chin, jaw, and neck as one coherent rhythm rather than isolated symbols.



Cheeks connect the face

Cheek volume mediates eyes, nose, mouth, and jaw.

A smile lifts the cheek and changes the lower eyelid. A face at rest still carries soft volume. Avoid flat masks and pinched transitions.



Neutral clay first

Construction problems are easier to see without color.

Review a simple clay pass before hair, skin, and fabric conceal the planes. Keep the broad animation-friendly structure through the final render.



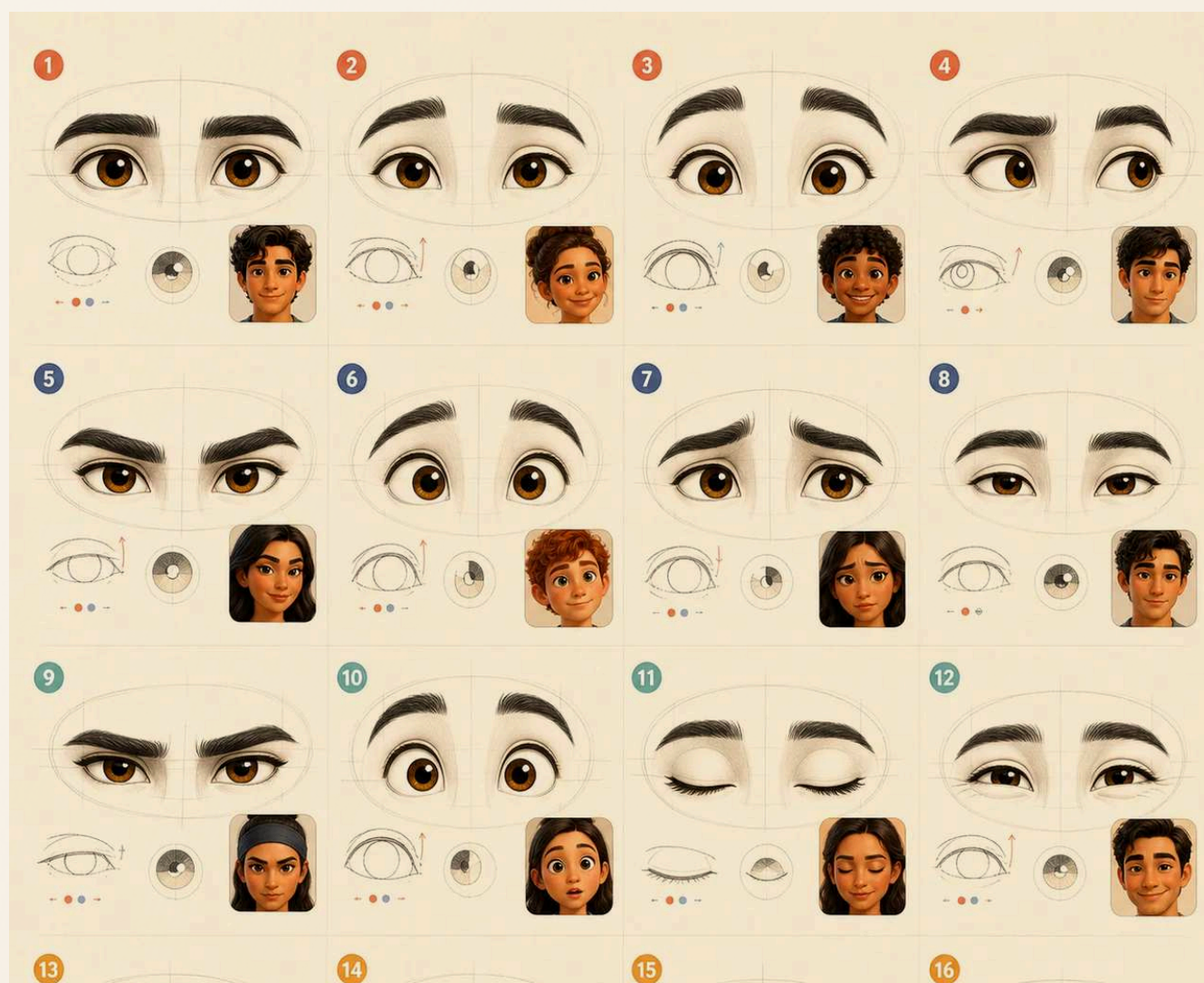
Construction checkpoint

The head should survive every angle.

- Cranium remains generous
- Features wrap around volume
- Profile reads as one rhythm
- Ears and neck track the turn
- Neutral clay preserves identity

Eyes and expression

Warmth lives in coordinated change.



Eyes sit in sockets

Stylized scale still needs believable lids and depth.

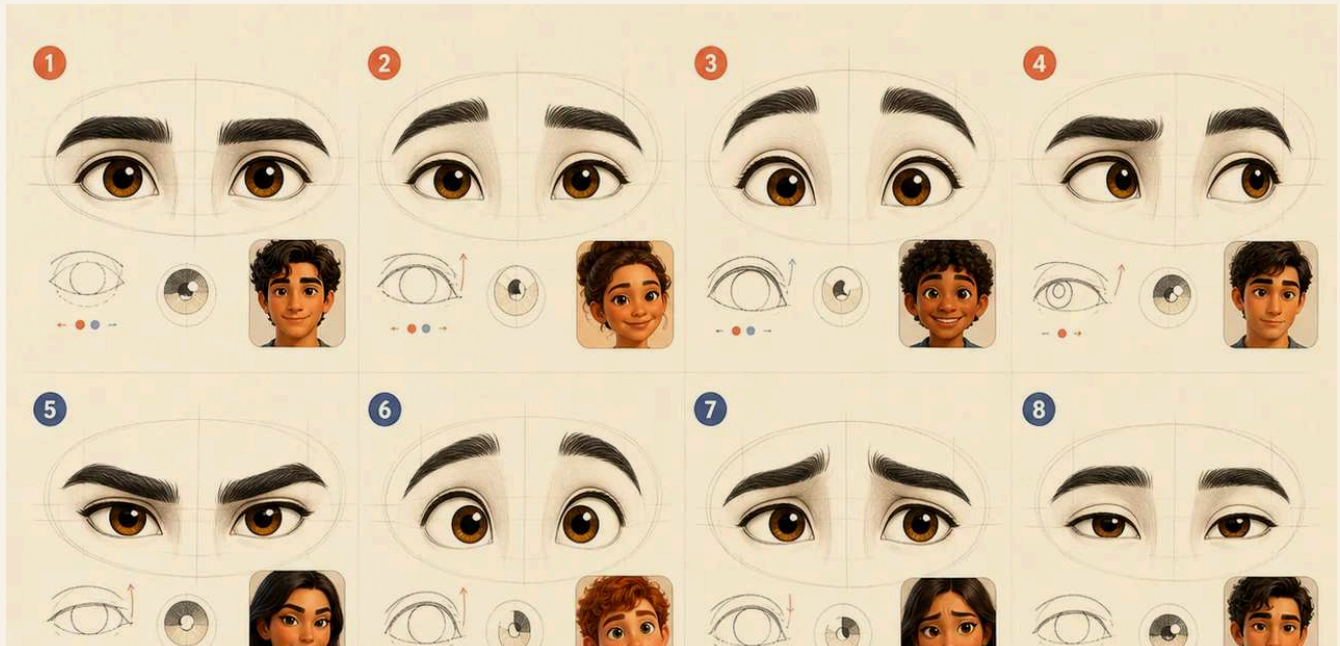
Weight the upper lid more than the lower. Let the eyeball turn inside the socket, and use one controlled catchlight system across both eyes.



Lid structure varies

Observe folds, exposure, tilt, and spacing independently.

Avoid one enlarged eye shape copied onto every face. The Palari language comes from warmth and clarity, not identical anatomy.



Avatar 003



Avatar 007



Avatar 010



Library study 02

Brows are rhythm

Brows connect thought, gaze, and attitude.

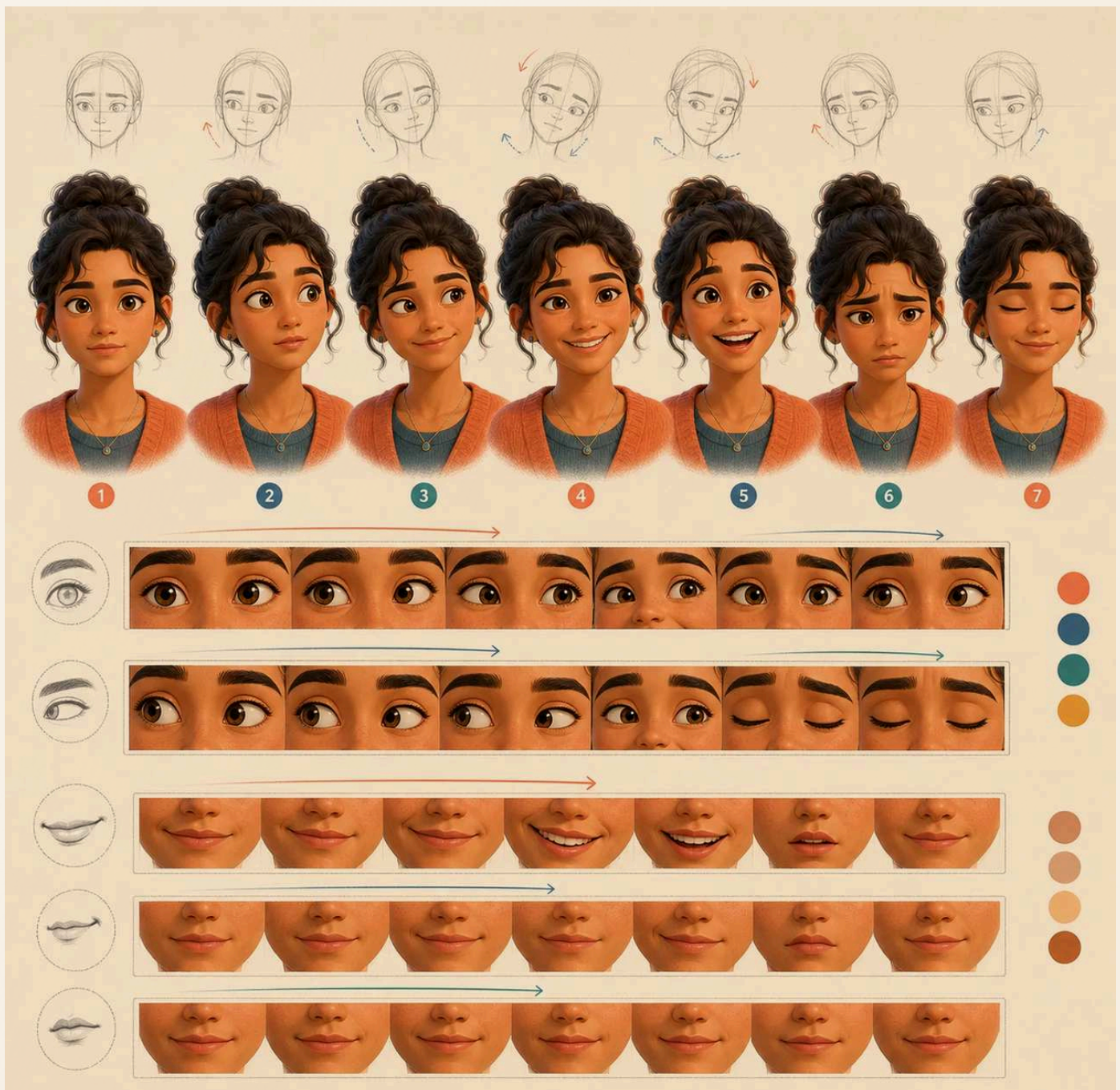
- Track the brow ridge
- Vary thickness and arc
- Coordinate with lids
- Keep asymmetry subtle



From neutral to smile

A believable expression changes more than the mouth.

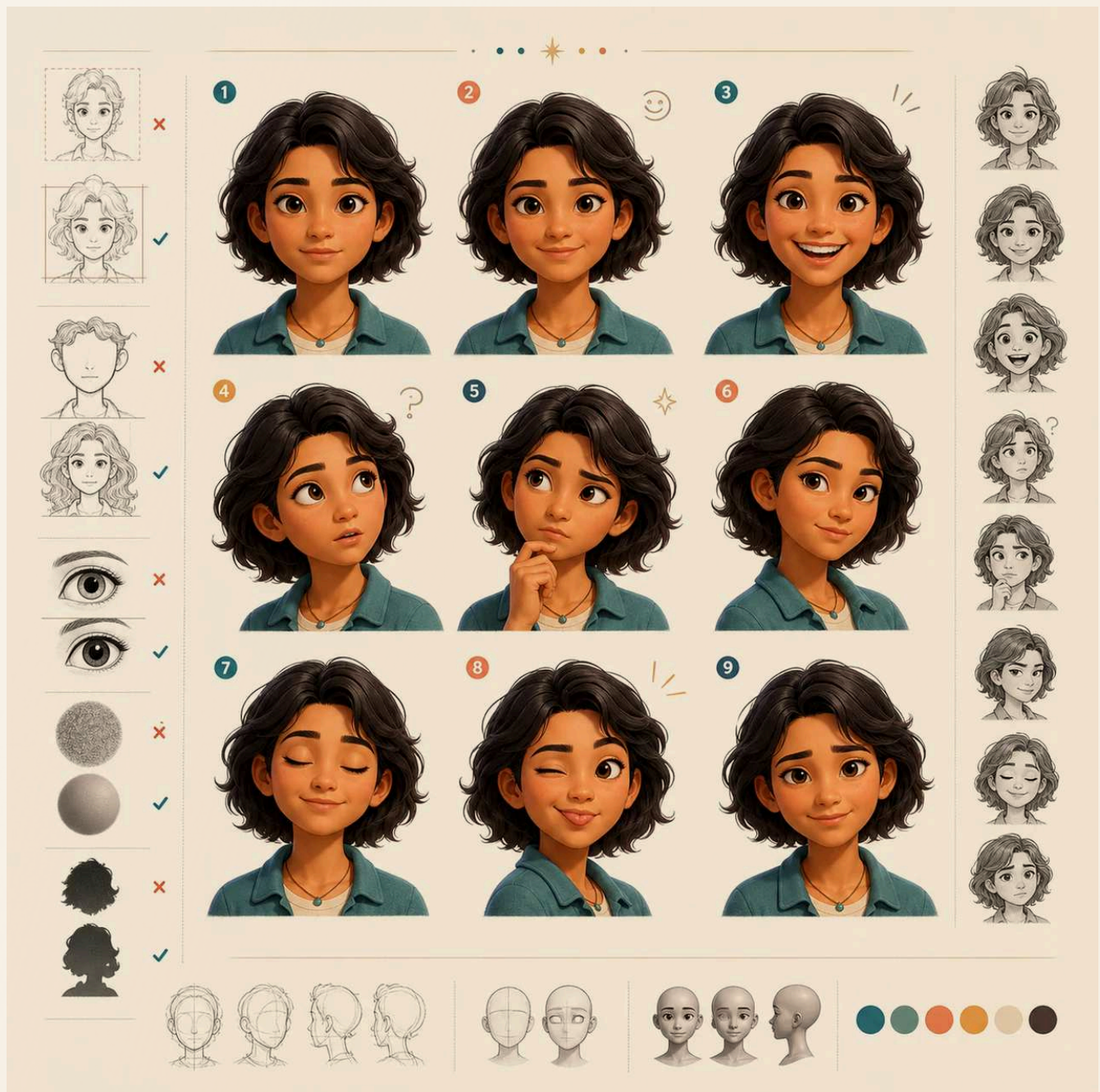
Watch the lower lids, cheek lift, nostril movement, lip corners, and jaw. Preserve the person at every intermediate state.



Quiet acting

Favor readable middle-range emotion over theatrical distortion.

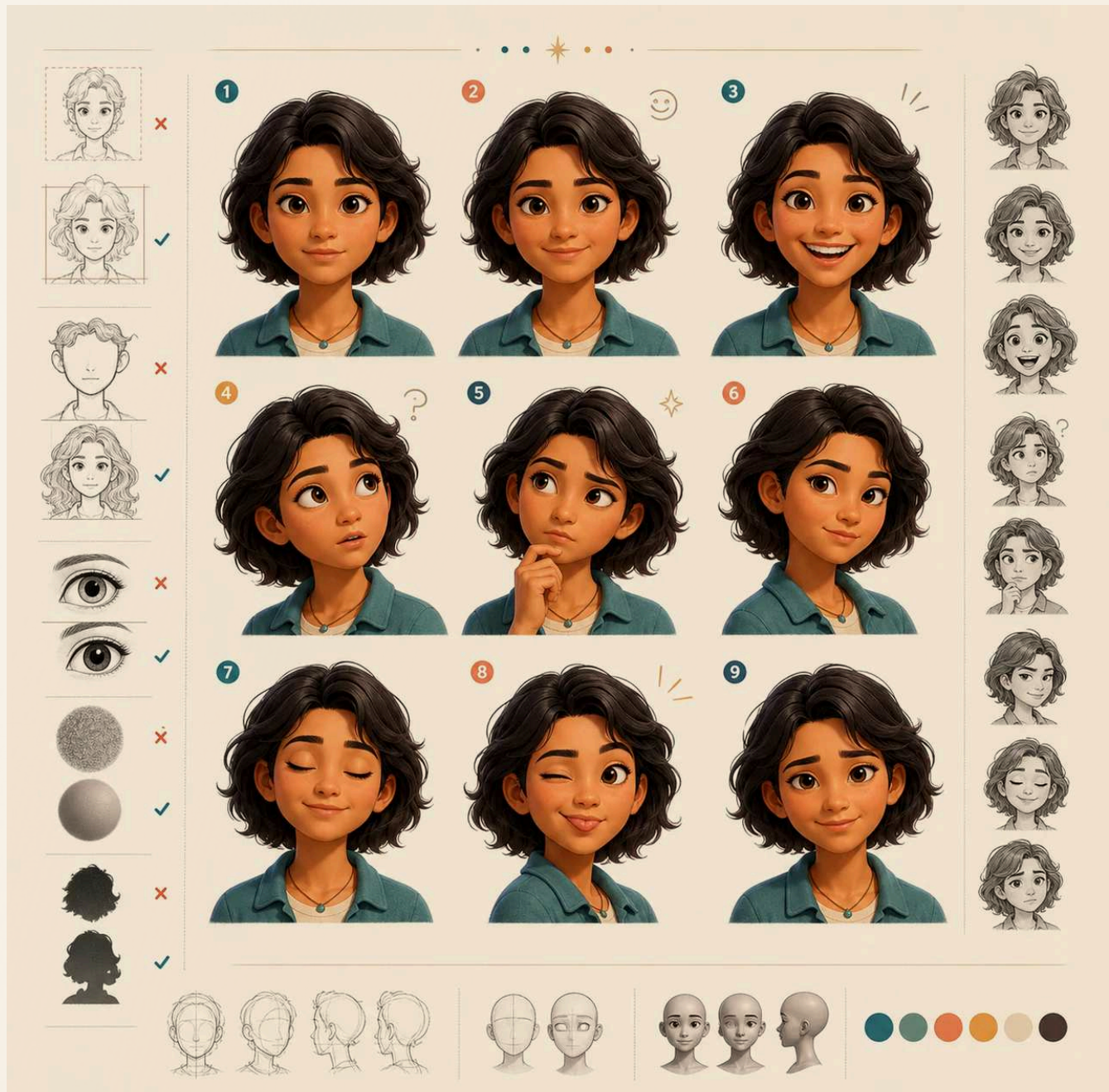
Palari expressions are present, friendly, and naturally asymmetric. Extreme squash, perfect mirroring, and symbolic eyebrows break the portrait language.



Gaze completes the pose

Eyes, lids, brows, and head direction share one intention.

A sideways glance without a head response feels disconnected. Let gaze guide small changes in brow, cheek, mouth, and shoulder rhythm.



Expression checkpoint

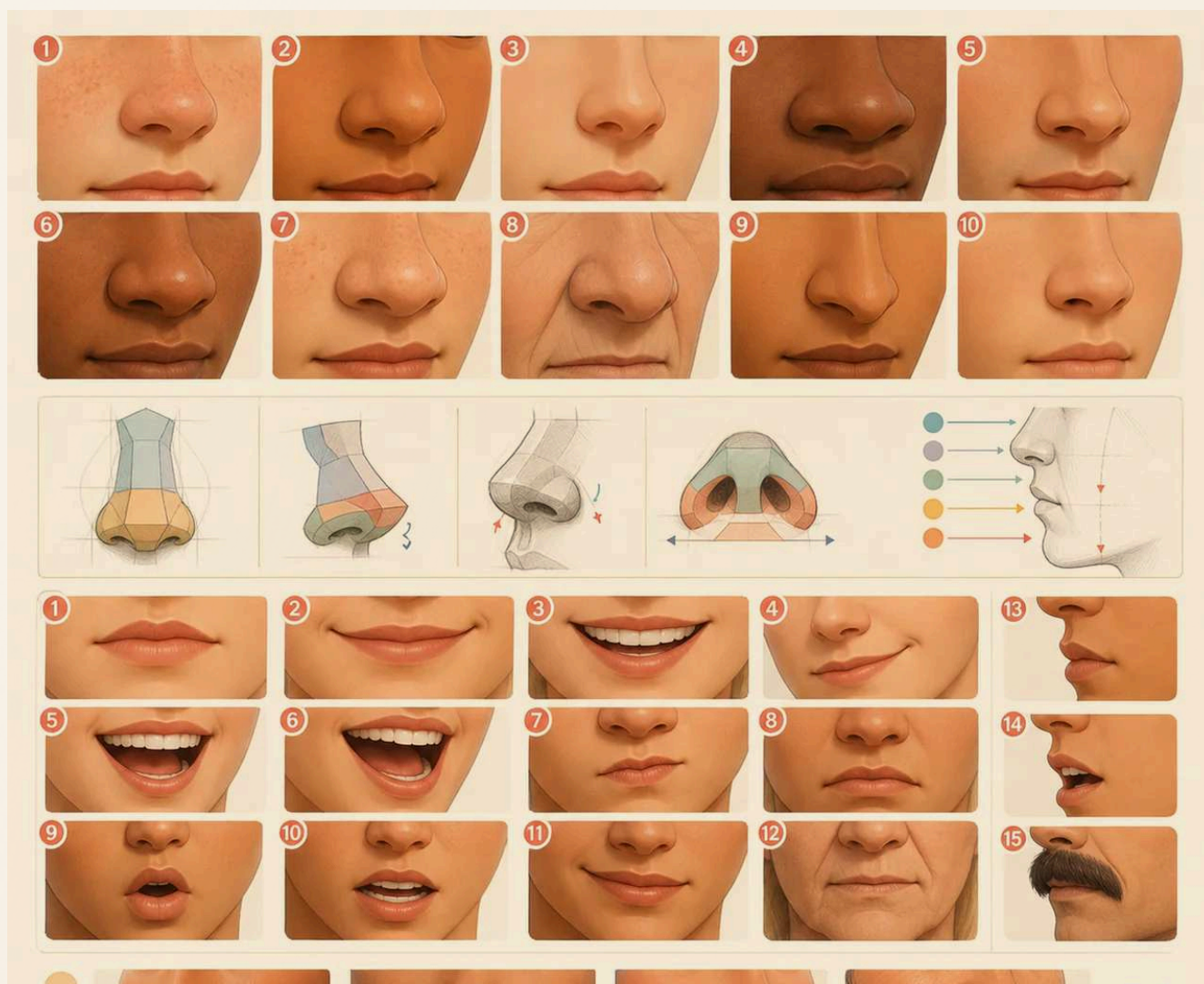
The face should feel alive without becoming a different character.

- Both eyes share one light system
- Lids follow the eyeballs
- Brows belong to the brow ridge
- Cheeks participate in smiles
- Identity survives every pose



Noses, mouths, and age

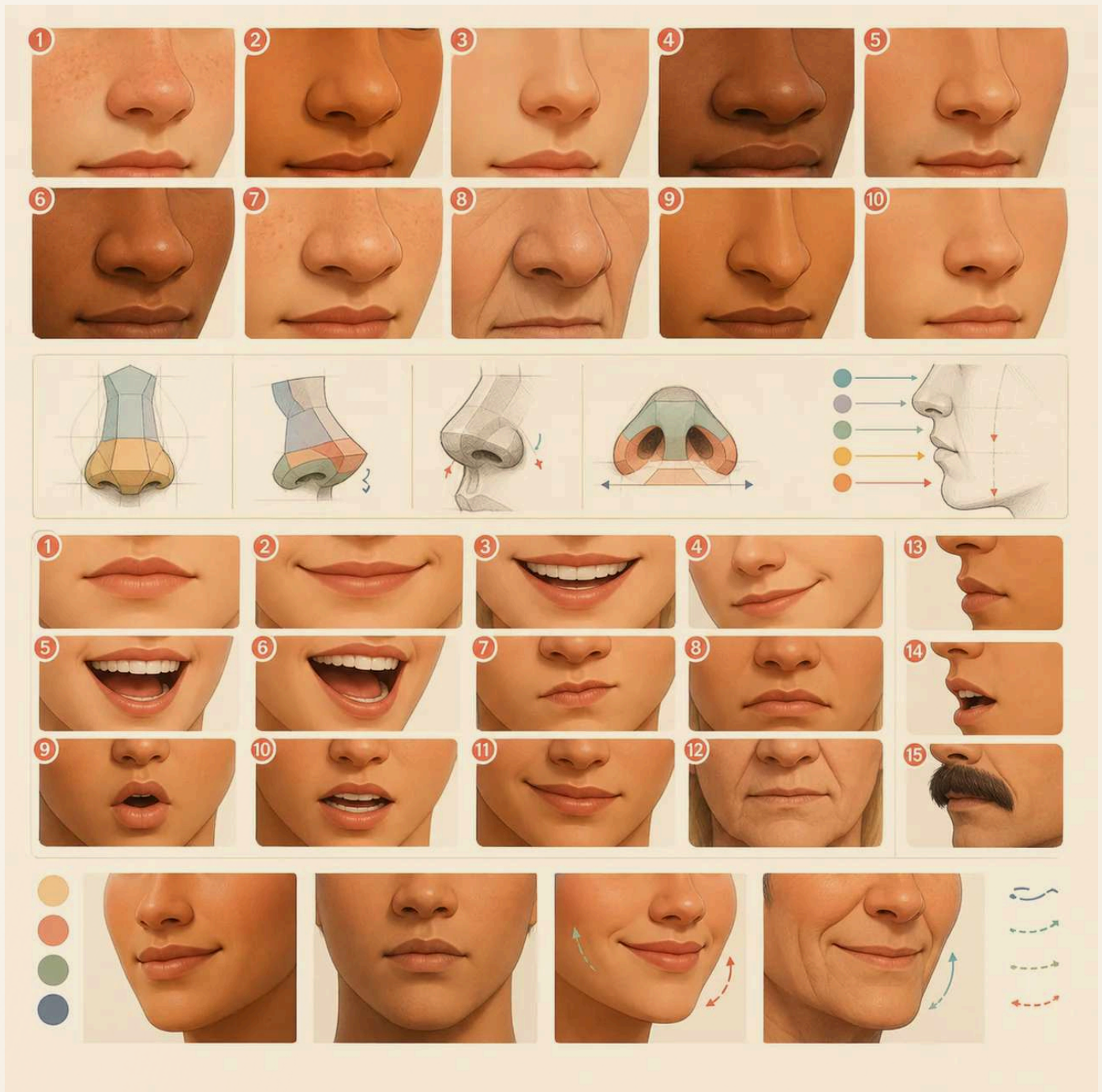
Small relationships create a specific face.



Nose architecture

Bridge, tip, wings, and nostrils form one volume.

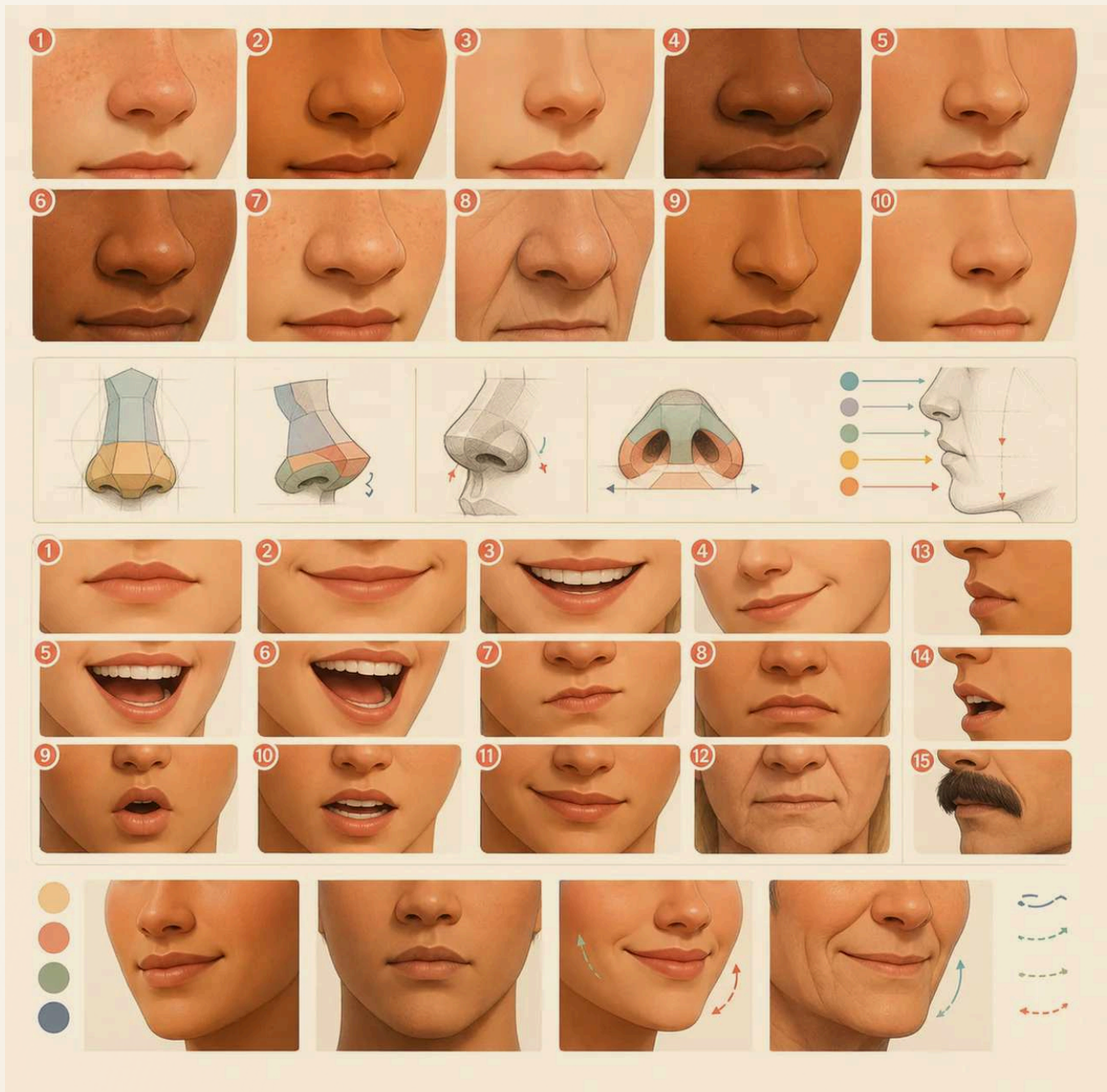
Preserve genuine variety in width, projection, angle, and nostril rhythm. Use a restrained underside shadow rather than outlining every edge.



Mouths retain volume

Even at rest, the lips wrap around the mouth barrel.

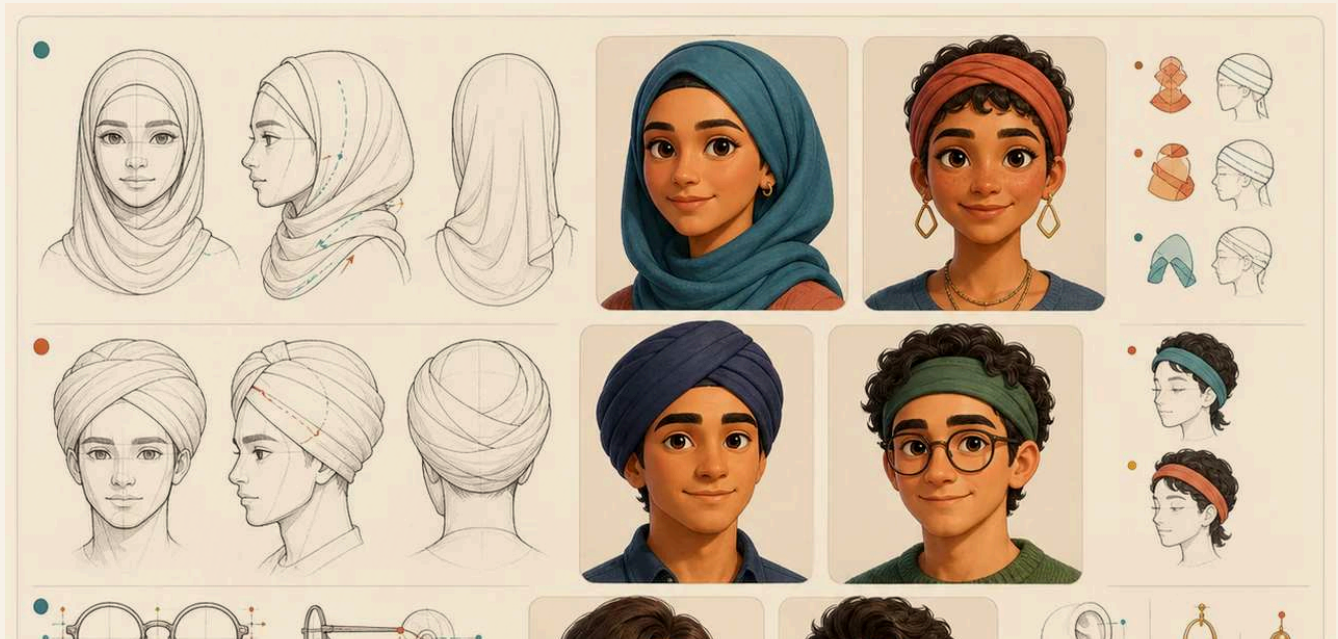
A smile alters cheeks and lower lids as well as lips. If teeth appear, group them as one quiet value instead of drawing individual tiles.



Facial hair follows form

Hair should reveal the jaw and mouth beneath it.

- Respect growth direction
- Preserve the lip line
- Keep beard mass readable
- Avoid pasted-on texture



Avatar 006



Avatar 009



Avatar 154

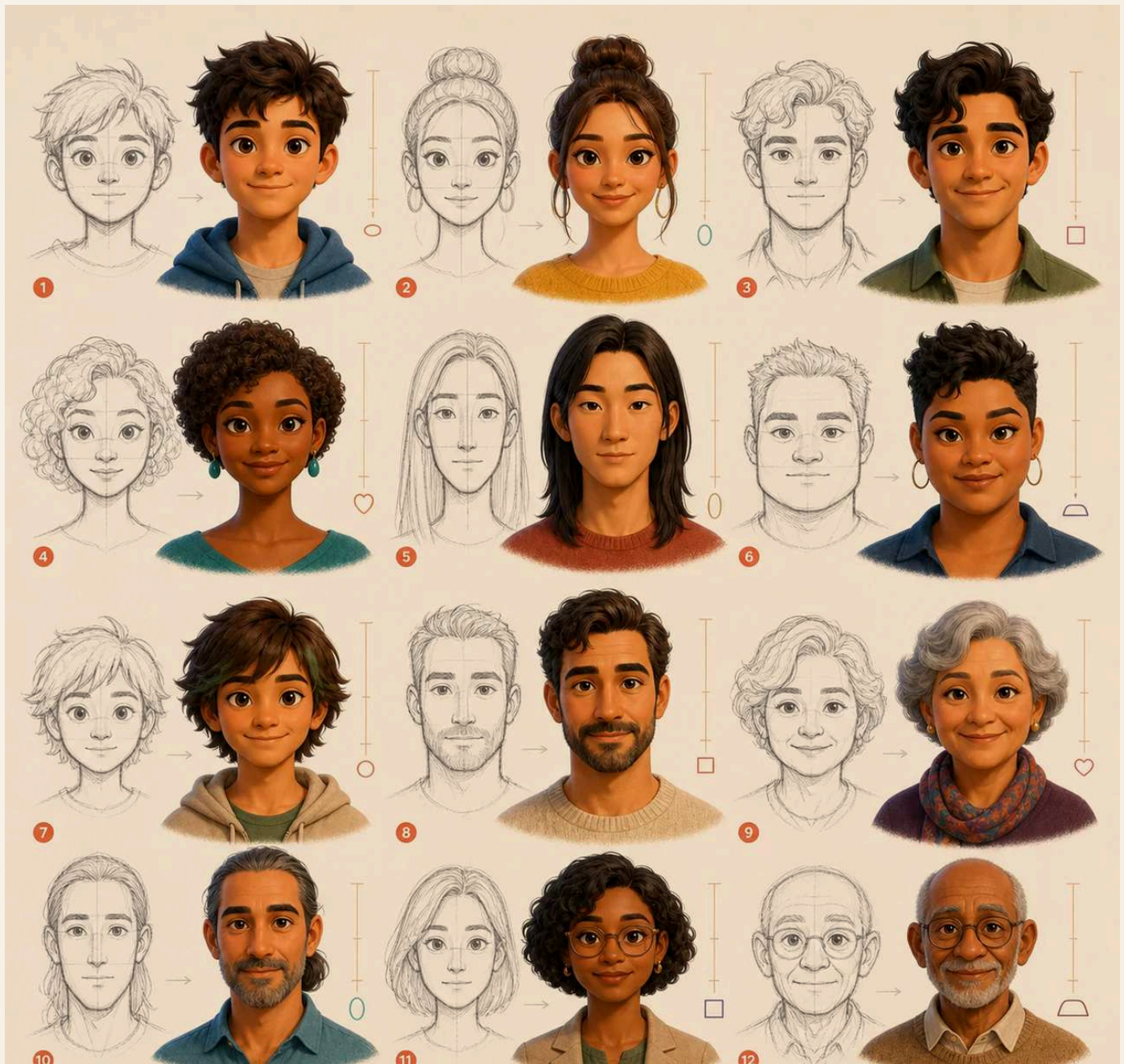


Avatar 155

Age changes planes

Proportion and support matter more than wrinkle count.

Study lid weight, cheek support, mouth volume, jaw transition, posture, and hair character. Keep older faces warm, dimensional, and individually designed.



Feature checkpoint

Specific without caricature.

- Nose reads as a volume
- Mouth wraps around the muzzle
- Smile coordinates the whole face
- Facial hair preserves structure
- Age is structural, not symbolic

Hair is architecture

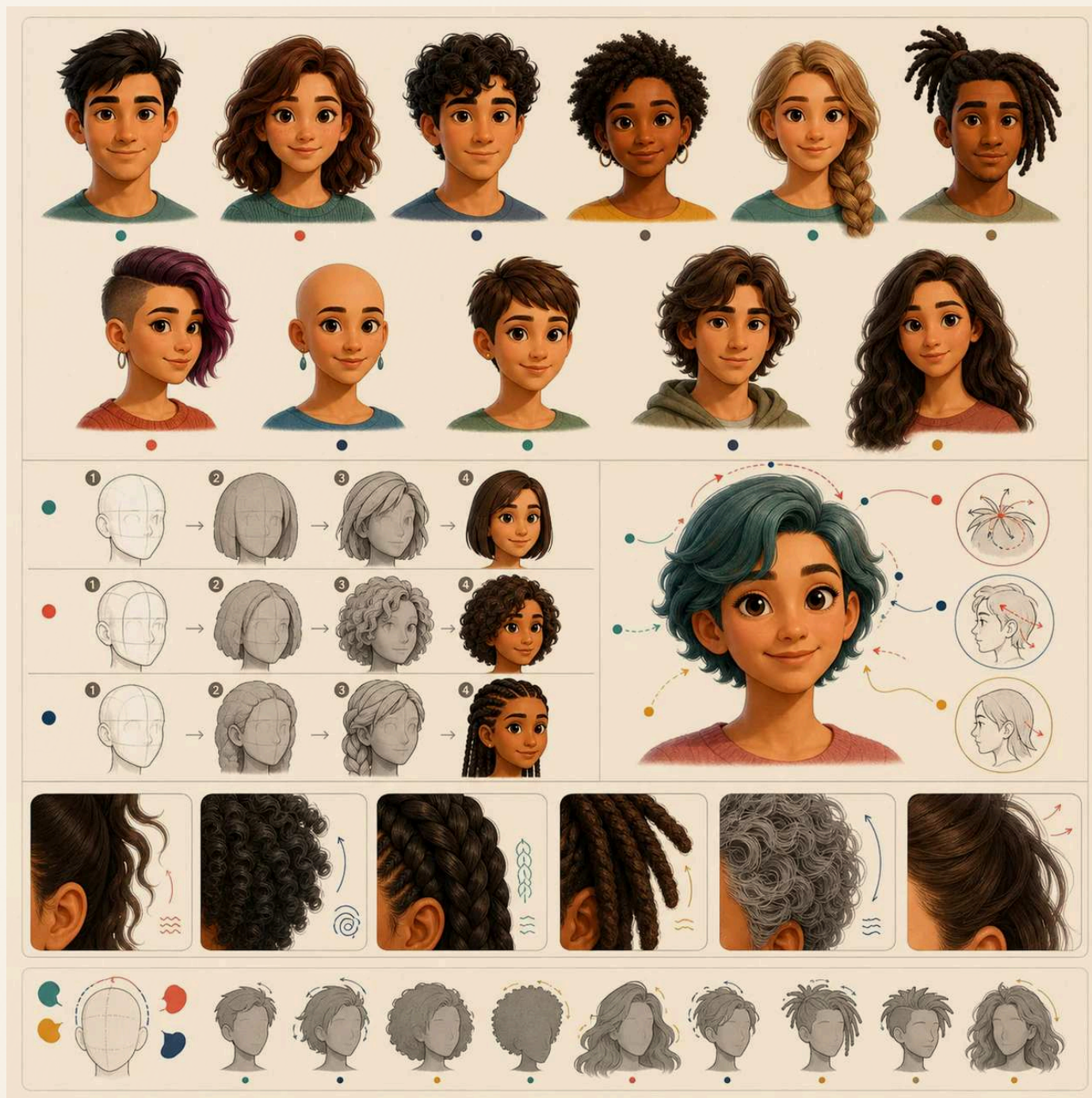
Build from large to small with intention.



Silhouette first

The outer shape defines how the hair reads at a glance.

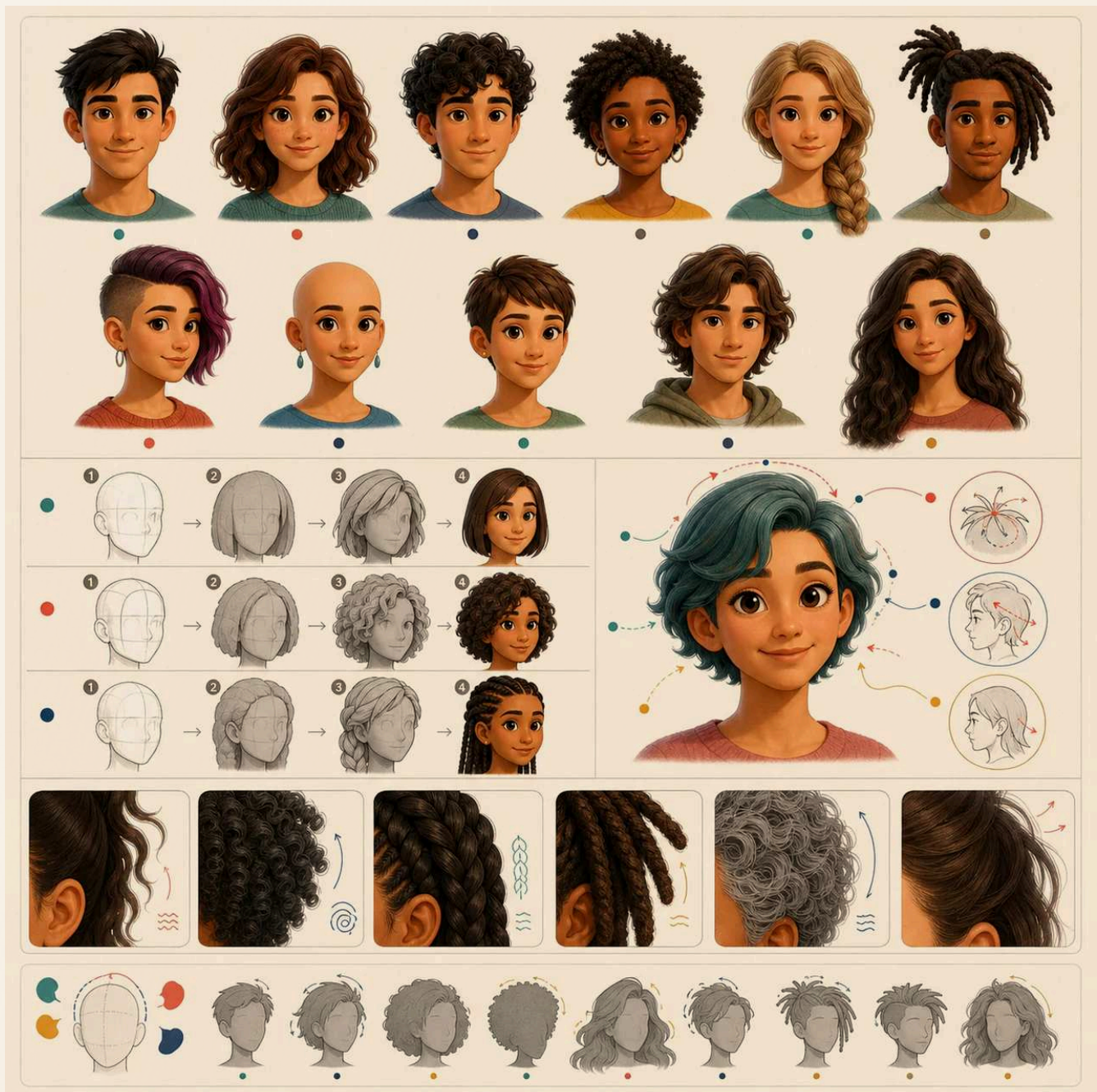
Preserve the skull beneath the design. Establish crown, hairline, weight, and balance before drawing clumps or individual strands.



Primary masses

Large forms carry most of the volume.

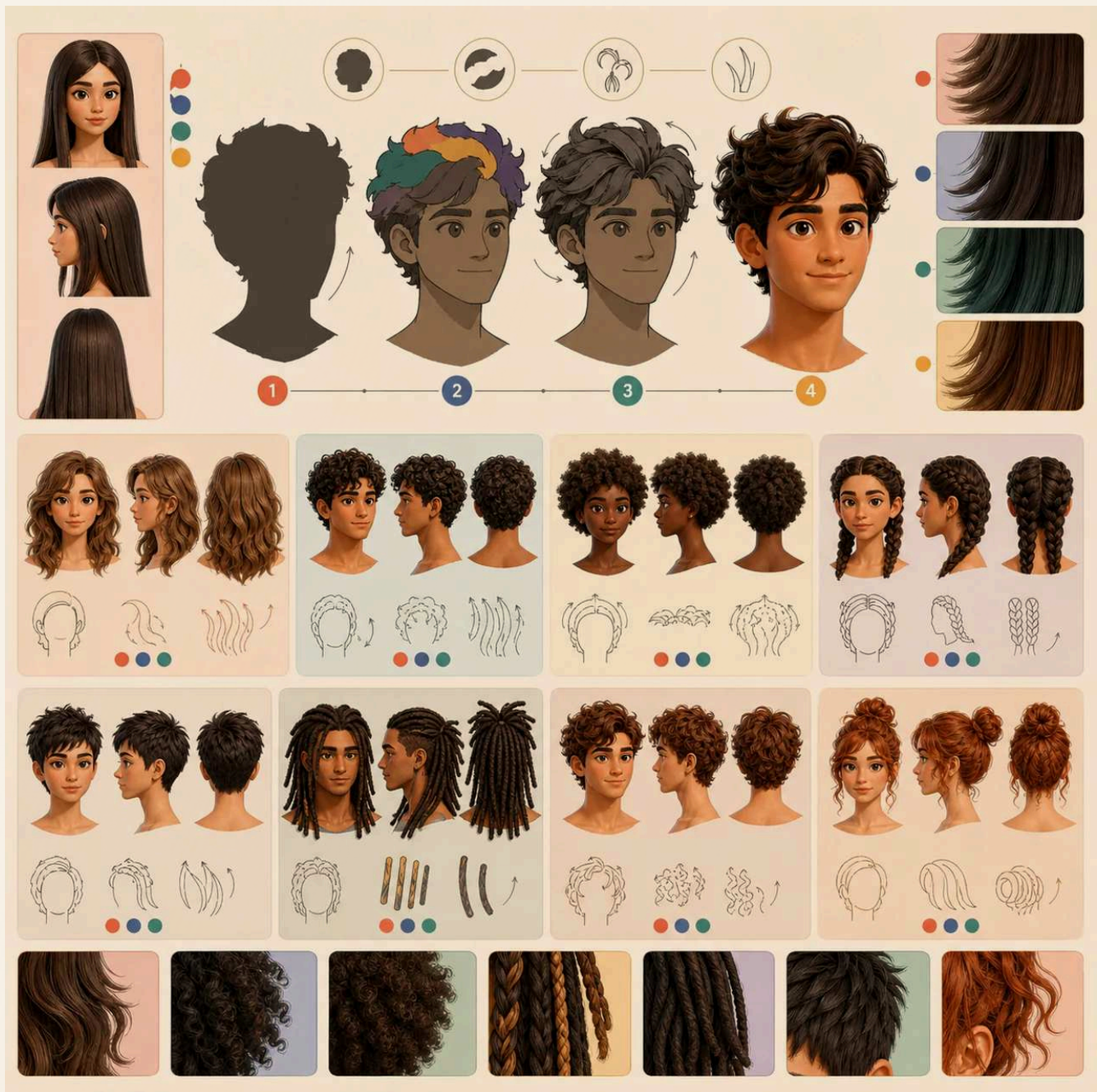
- Straight hair: clean ribbons
- Waves: broad S-curves
- Curls: grouped coils
- Coils: clustered volume
- Braids and locs: repeated forms with variation



Secondary clumps

Mid-size groups create rhythm and overlap.

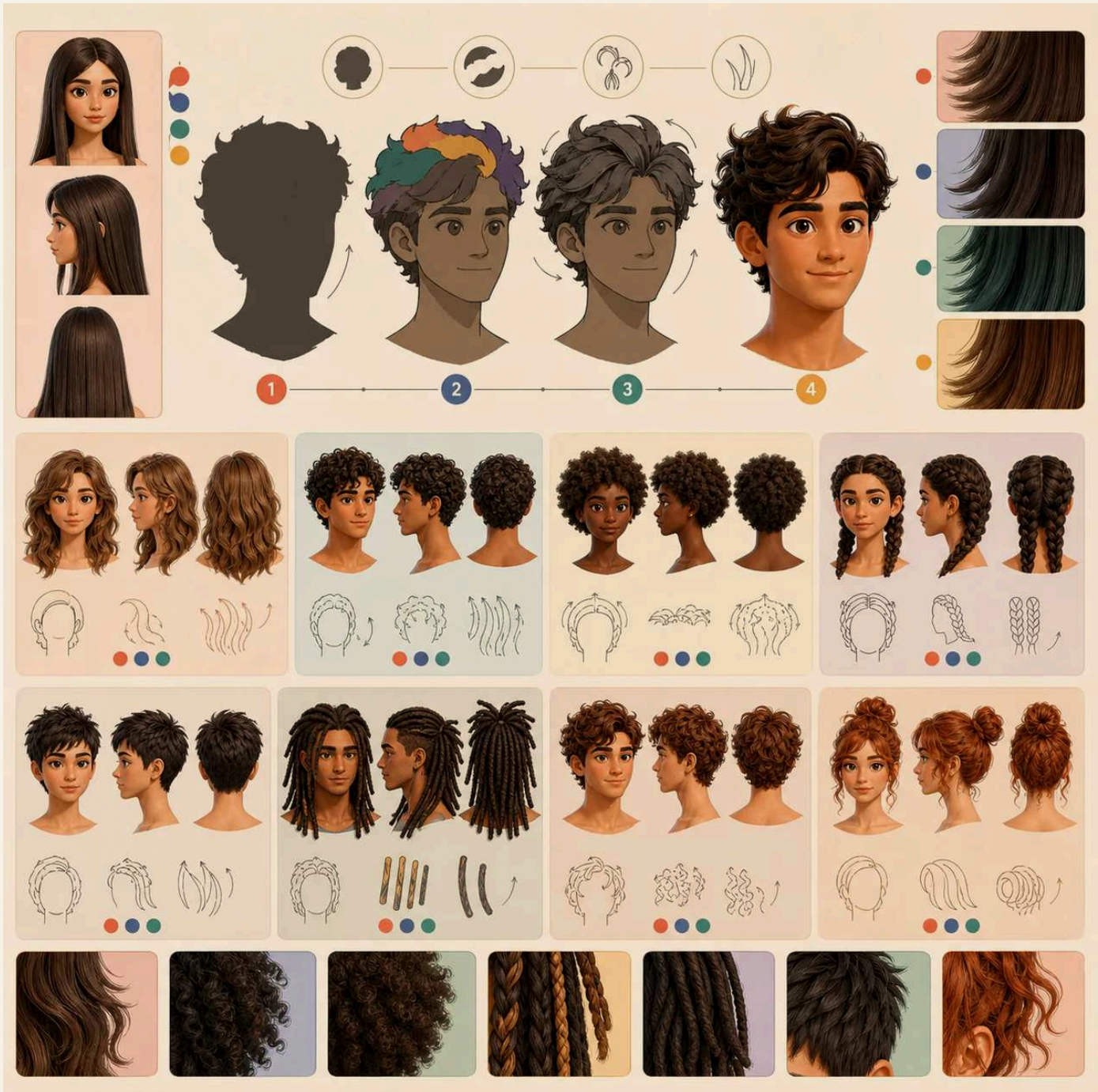
Break the large silhouette where the flow turns, where masses overlap, and where gravity changes direction. Do not distribute detail evenly.



Selective strands

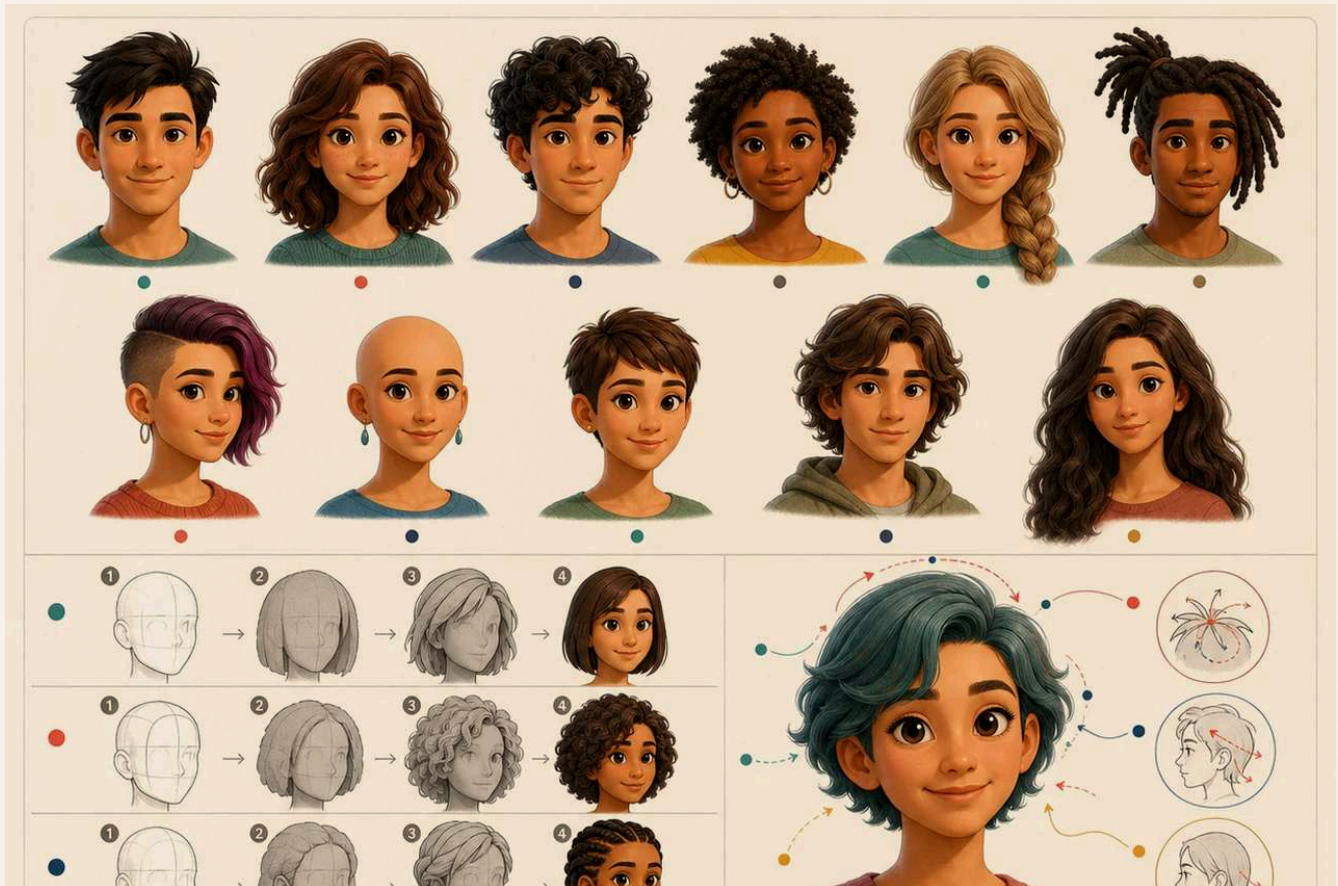
A few purposeful strands add life.

Flyaways belong primarily at the silhouette and near meaningful overlaps. Random fuzz across the whole hairstyle destroys the large design.



Hair structures

Different structures need different edge languages.



Avatar 147

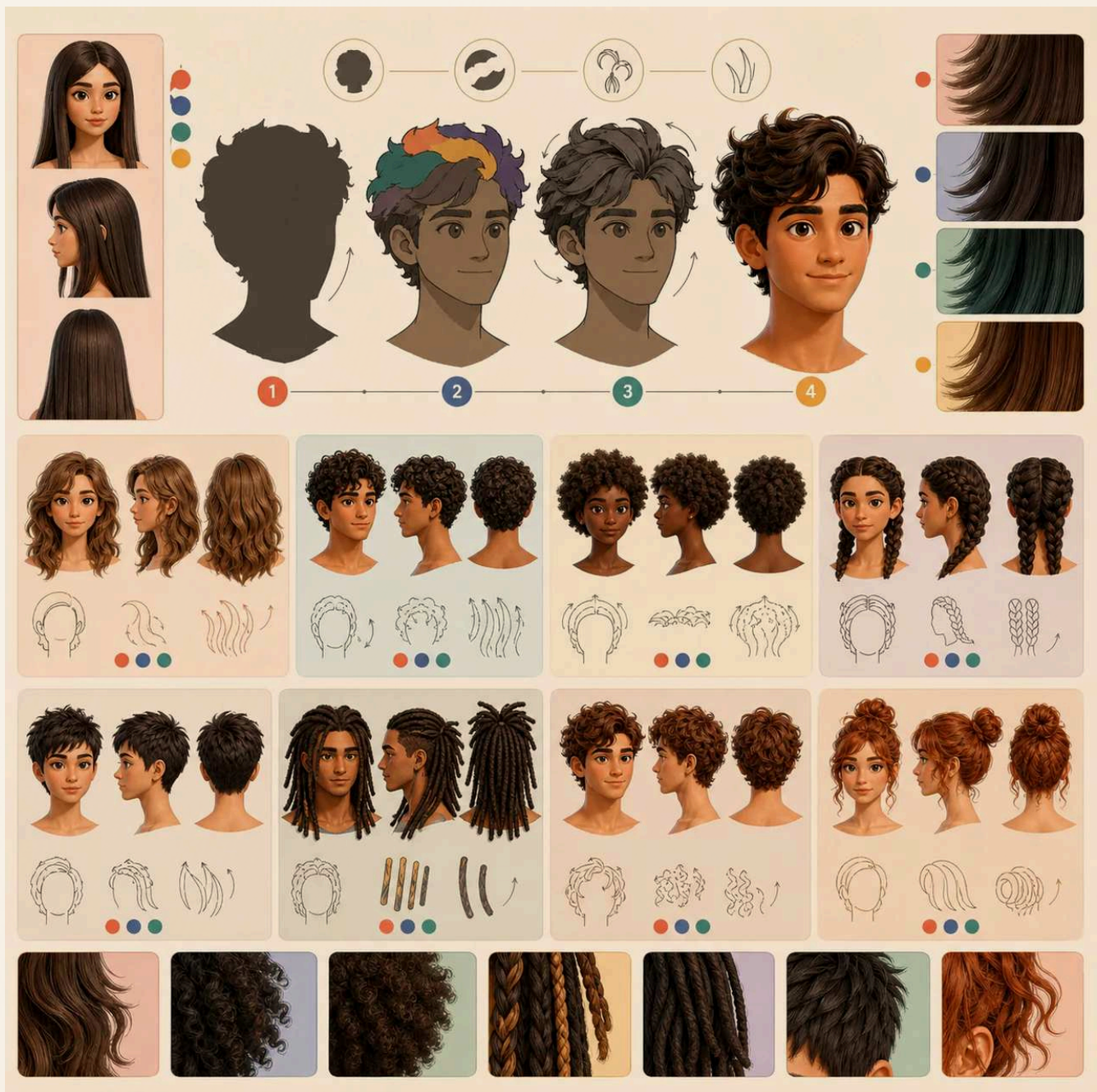


Avatar 149

Shoulder overlaps

Long hair and garments must remain independently readable.

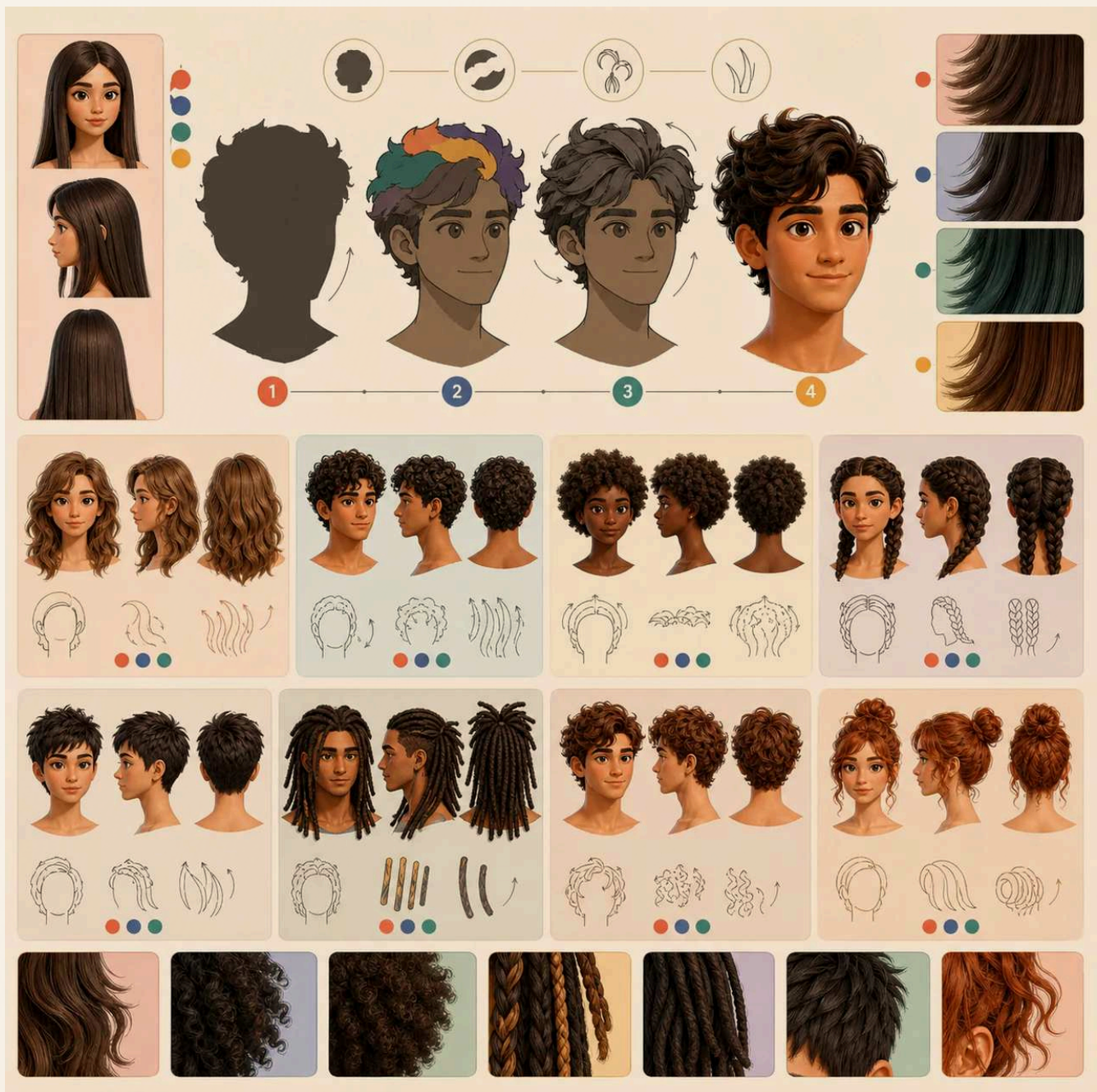
Design each overlap. Keep the neckline, neck, shoulder, and hair edge distinct enough for color changes and masking without flattening the artwork.



Avoid the halo

Bright edge accents must describe hair, not borrowed background color.

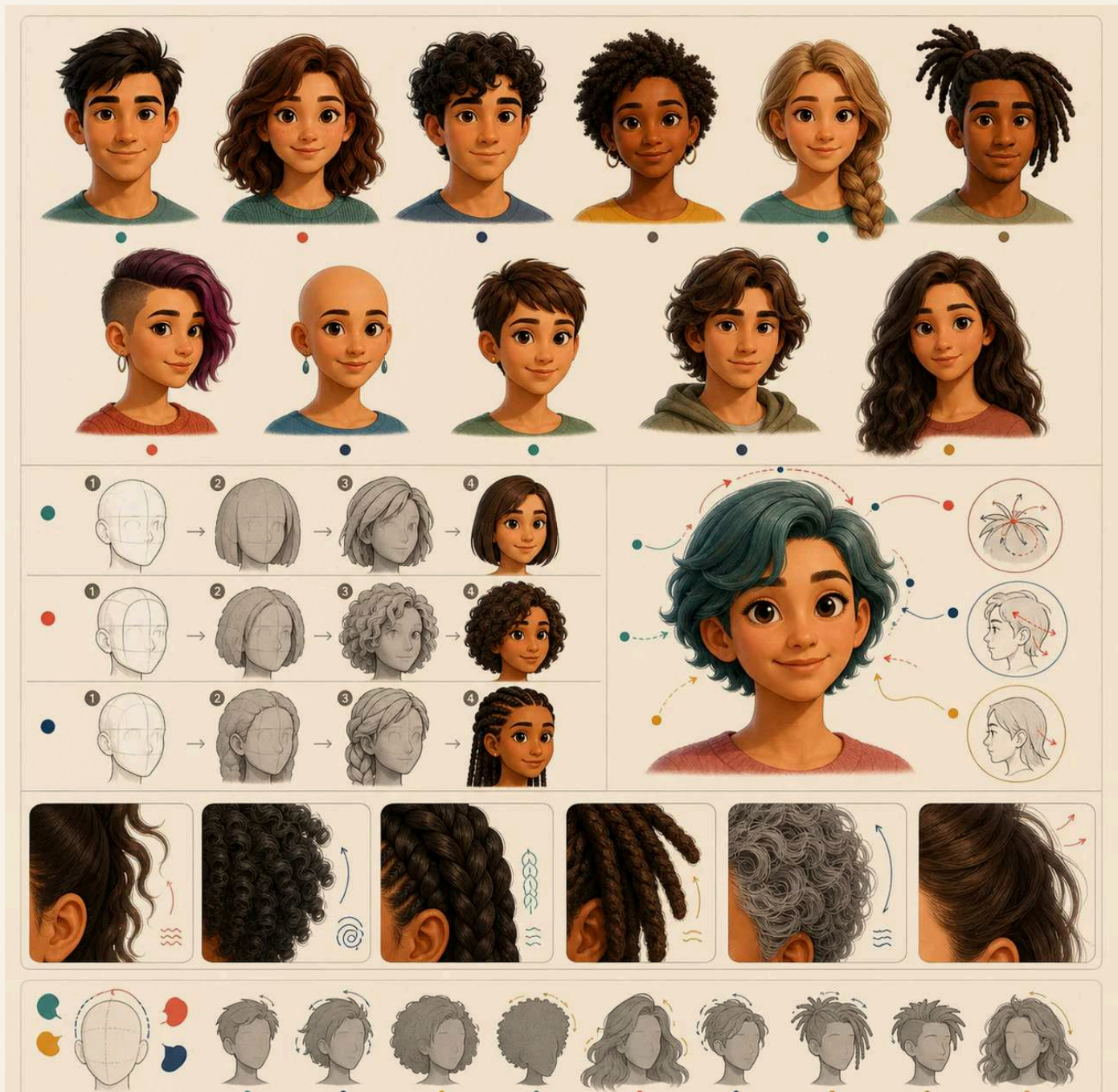
Check fine curls and flyaways against light, dark, warm, and cool backgrounds. Reject colored outlines that move when the background changes.



Review at two scales

Silhouette first. Edge detail second.

At thumbnail size, judge volume and flow. At full size, judge clean antialiasing, controlled flyaways, and separation from skin, earrings, and garment.



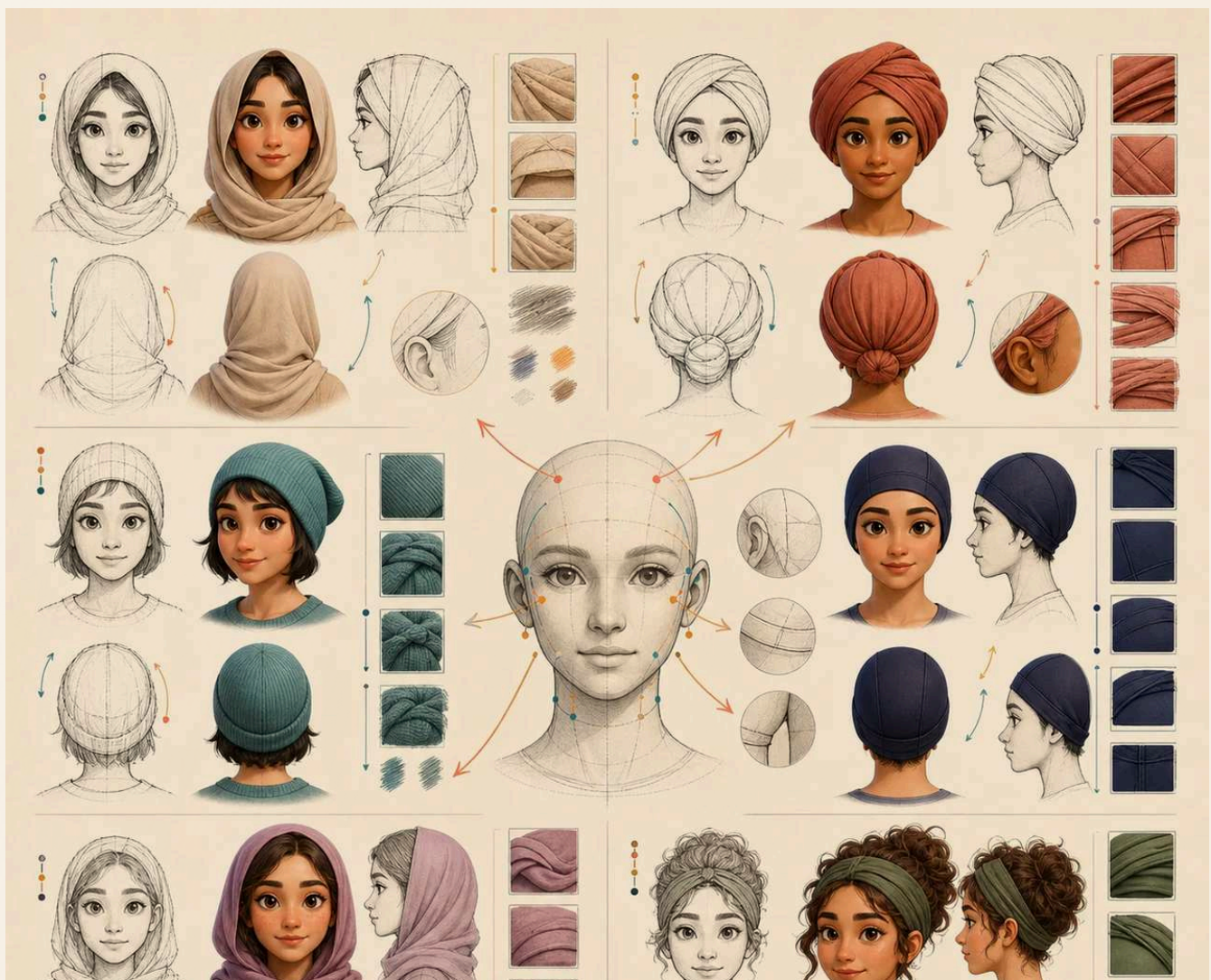
Hair checkpoint

Architecture before texture.

- Skull remains believable
- Silhouette reads small
- Primary masses carry volume
- Flyaways are selective
- Neckline and shoulders stay readable
- No background-colored halo

Headwear and garments

Construction, weight, and respectful specificity.



Headwear follows the skull

Anchor points and tension create believable wrapping.

Define the skull first, then fabric thickness, anchor points, compression, overlap, gravity, and the direction of tension.



Fabric mechanics

Wrapped, draped, knitted, woven, and elastic materials fold differently.

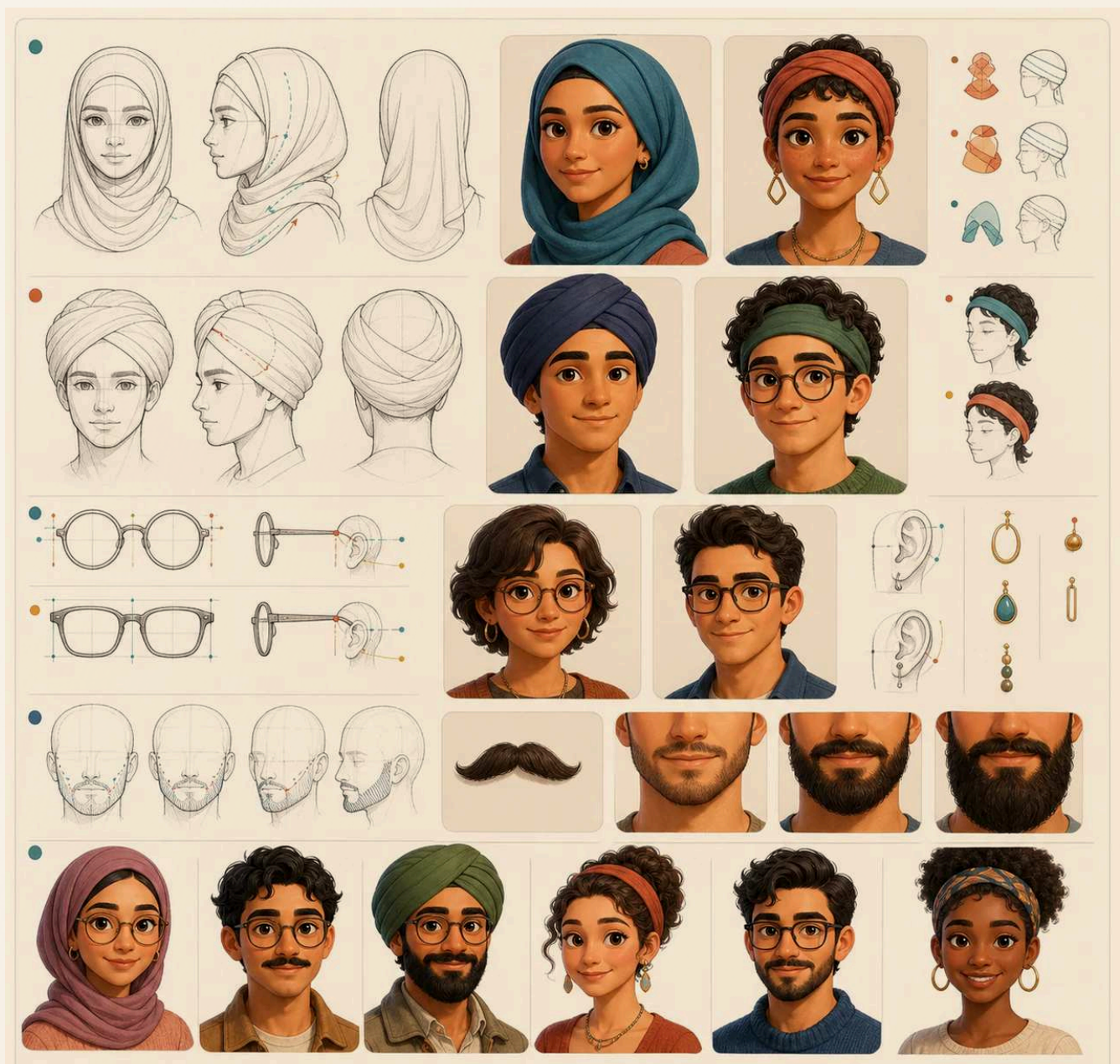
Use front, side, and back references so folds remain physically continuous instead of becoming decorative lines with no cause.



Accessories support the face

They should clarify personality without taking hierarchy.

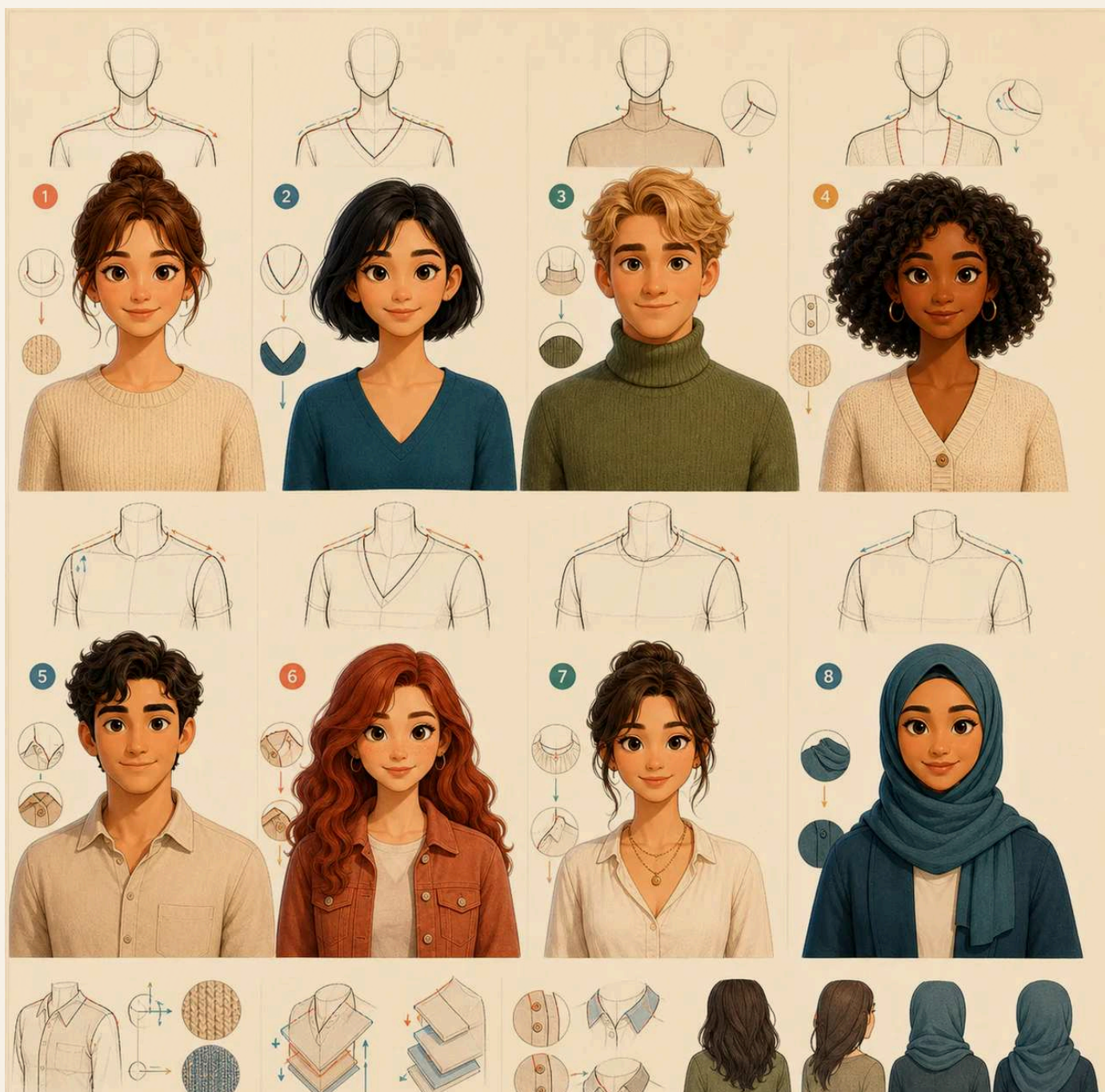
- Glasses track head perspective
- Lenses preserve the eyes
- Jewelry has believable attachment
- Metal highlights stay small



The shoulder base

The garment anchors the lower composition.

Keep both shoulders complete with a believable slope. Preserve enough upper chest for the portrait to feel grounded and for garment masks to remain useful.



Neckline authority

The garment must separate cleanly from neck, hair, beard, and headwear.

Collars have thickness. Layers overlap. Knit follows form. A neckline should never consume skin or hair when recolored.



Material before texture

Structure identifies fabric before surface grain does.

Use a few structural folds, then add restrained material-specific texture. Noise cannot substitute for weight, thickness, and overlap.



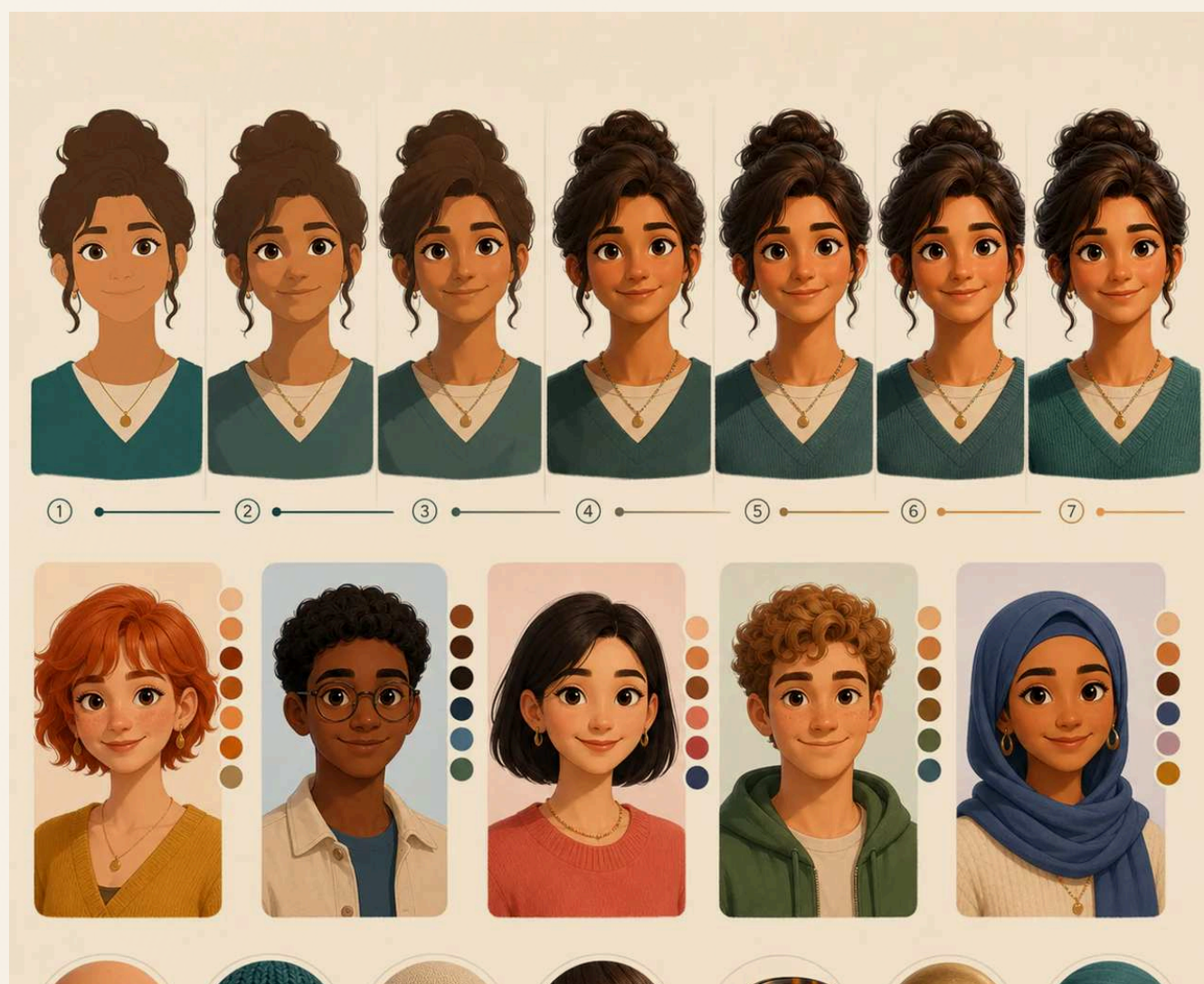
Wardrobe checkpoint

Respect construction and preserve boundaries.

- Headwear follows the skull
- Folds have physical causes
- Accessories track perspective
- Both shoulders are complete
- Neck and hair remain protected

Light, color, and materials

Soft studio light, clear local color, restrained detail.



One light world

Skin, hair, fabric, glass, and metal share the same illumination.

Use a soft warm key, gentle fill, and controlled highlights. The face should feel dimensional without cinematic drama or hard rim lighting.



Material response

Texture explains the surface; it does not decorate it.

- Skin: soft response
- Hair: grouped sheen
- Knit: form-following grain
- Glass: clear lenses
- Metal: small highlights



Five-part palette

Skin, hair, garment, accessories, and background must remain distinct.

Choose colors as a value system before chasing hue. Related colors may coexist if their boundaries and value structure stay clear.



Background harmony

Test light, mid-value, warm, and cool families.

Fine hair edges must remain believable on every approved background. The background supports the face rather than becoming a colored outline.



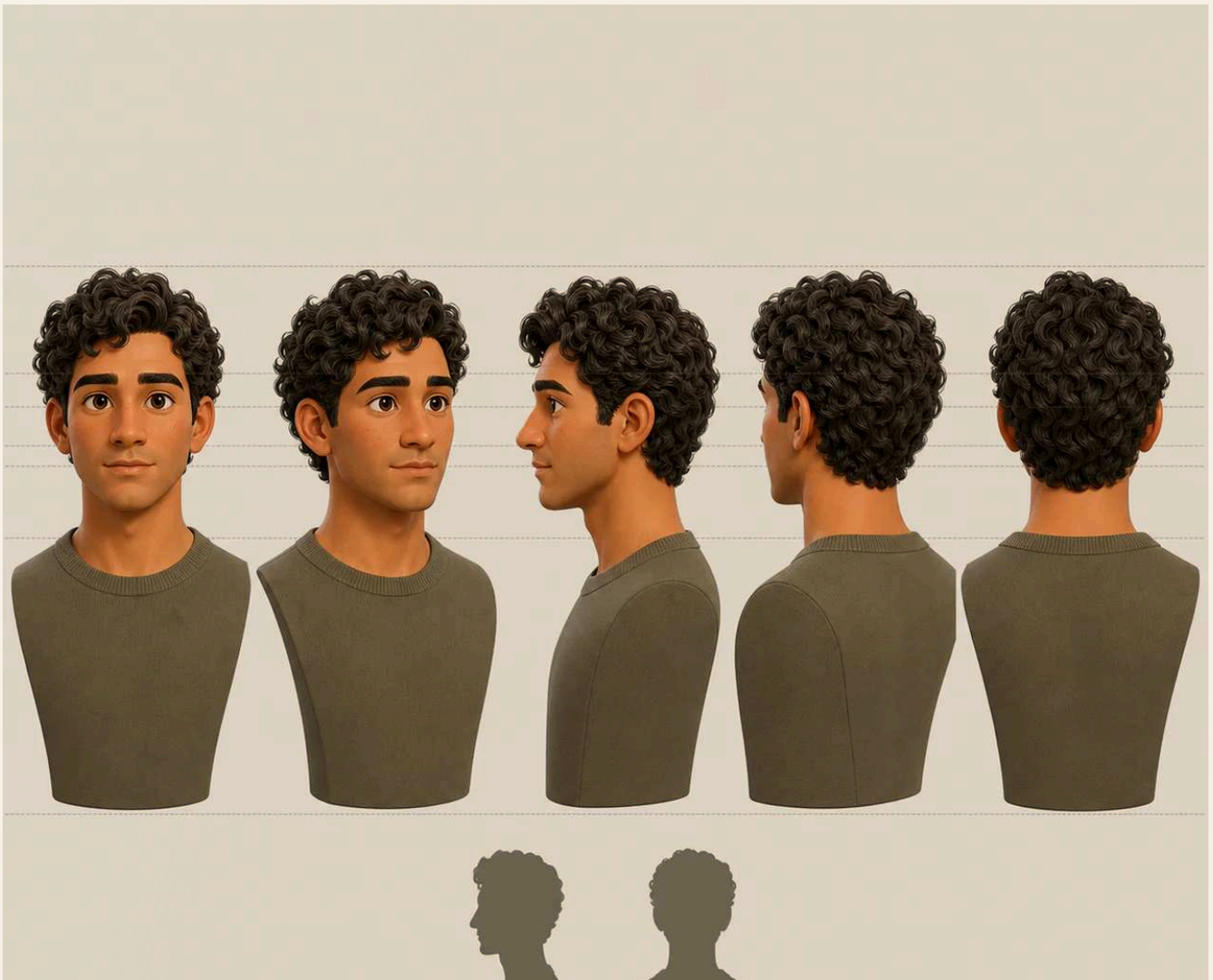
Material checkpoint

Clean local color before polish.

- Light direction is coherent
- Value groups remain separate
- Texture follows form
- No sharpening halos or dirty grain
- Palette survives background changes

Framing, rotation, and 3D

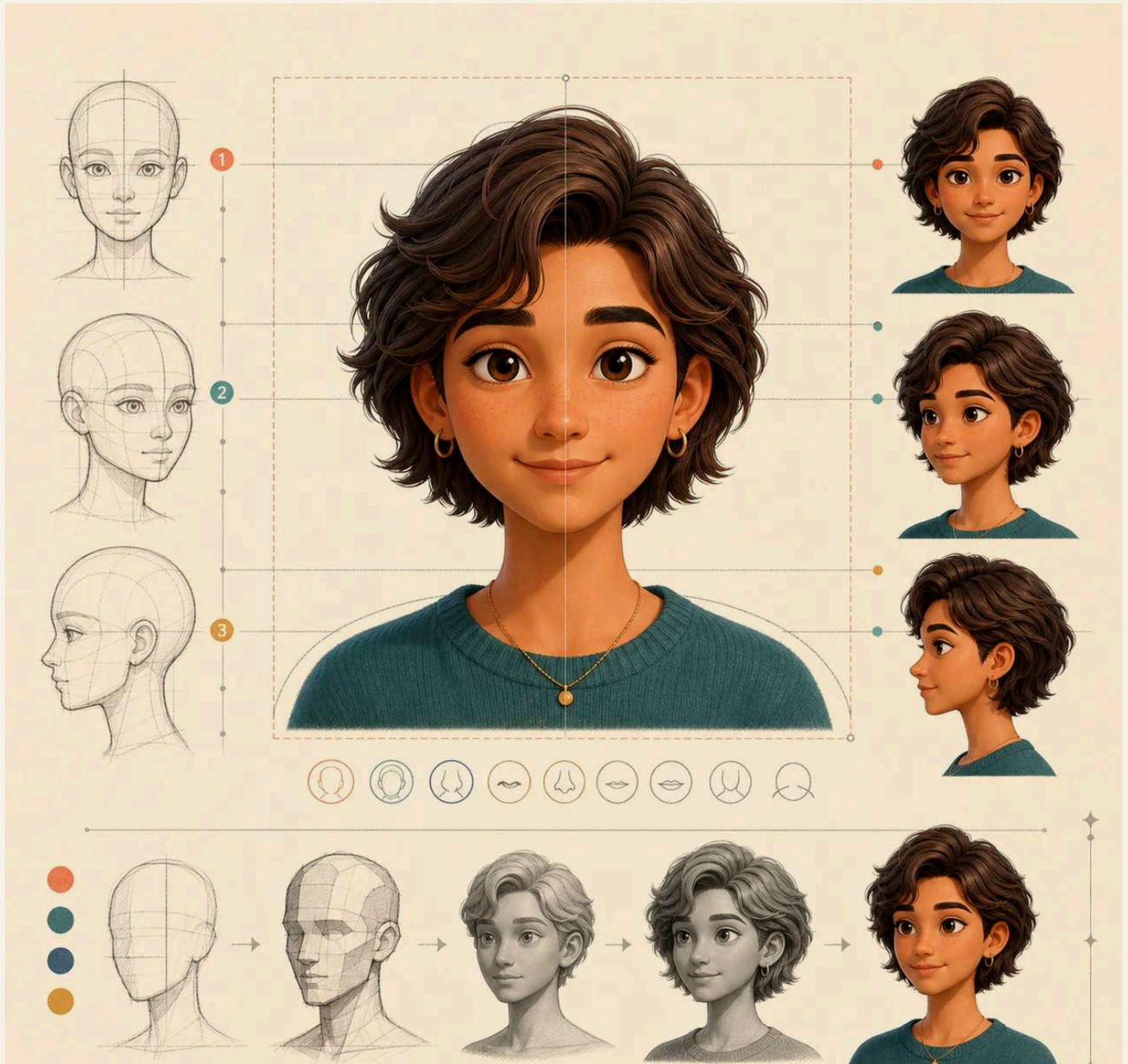
One identity must survive space.



Face-aware framing

Standardize composition without pre-cropping the source.

Apply one reviewed scale-and-center transform to the portrait and every aligned mask layer. Never transform the source, hair, foreground, and garment independently.



Complete rotation

Front, three-quarter, profile, and back remove guesswork.

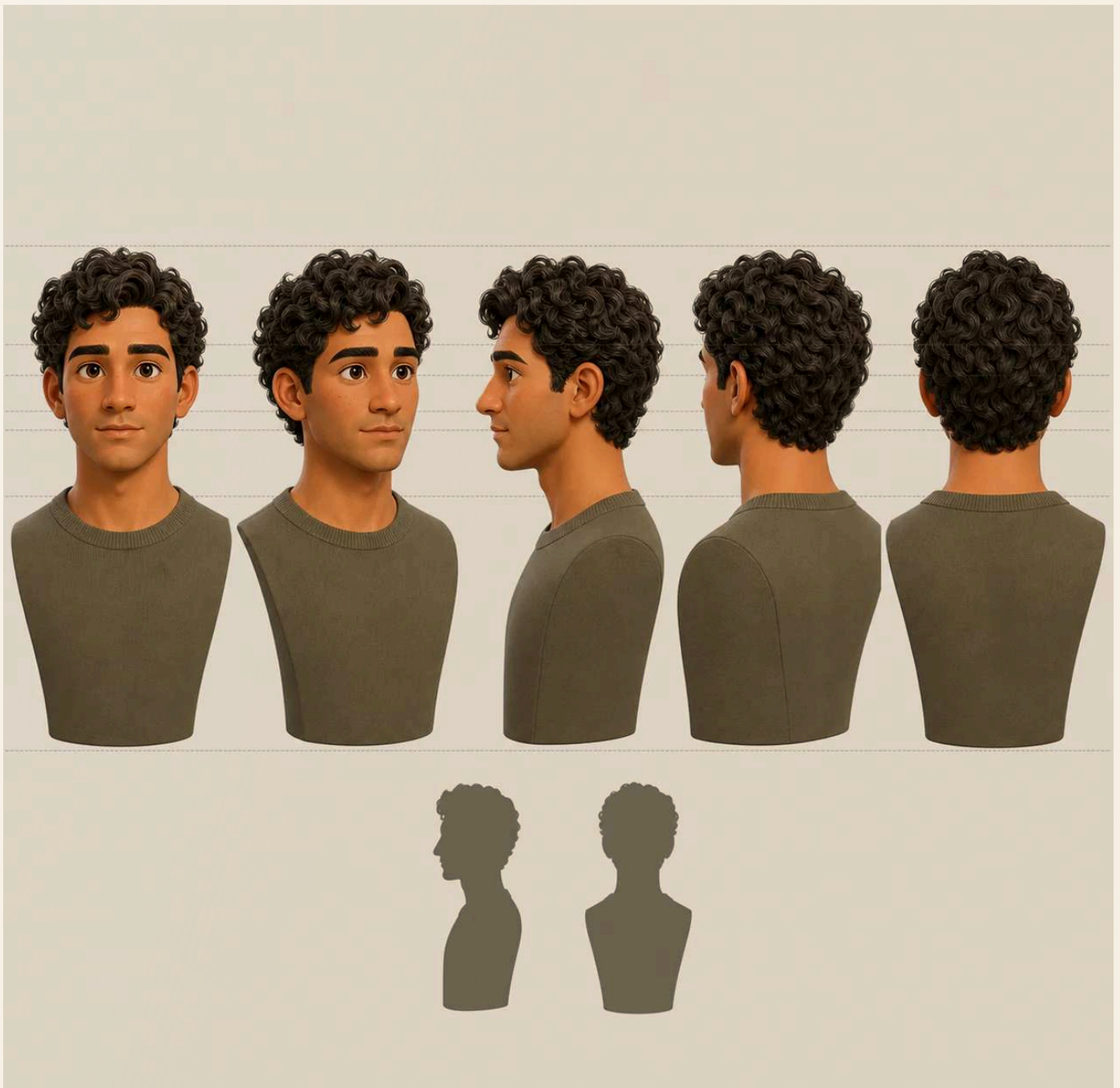
Track skull, ears, feature guides, hair volume, neckline, and shoulder width through one consistent camera and scale.



Orthographic approval

Approve the turnaround before production modeling.

Use neutral front, three-quarter, profile, and back views. Keep head tilt, camera height, scale, and landmarks locked.



From sculpt to material

Solve the character in clay before surface polish.

Model head, neck, shoulders, eyes, hair, garment, and accessories as production-friendly parts. Then add restrained Palari skin, hair, fabric, glass, and metal materials.



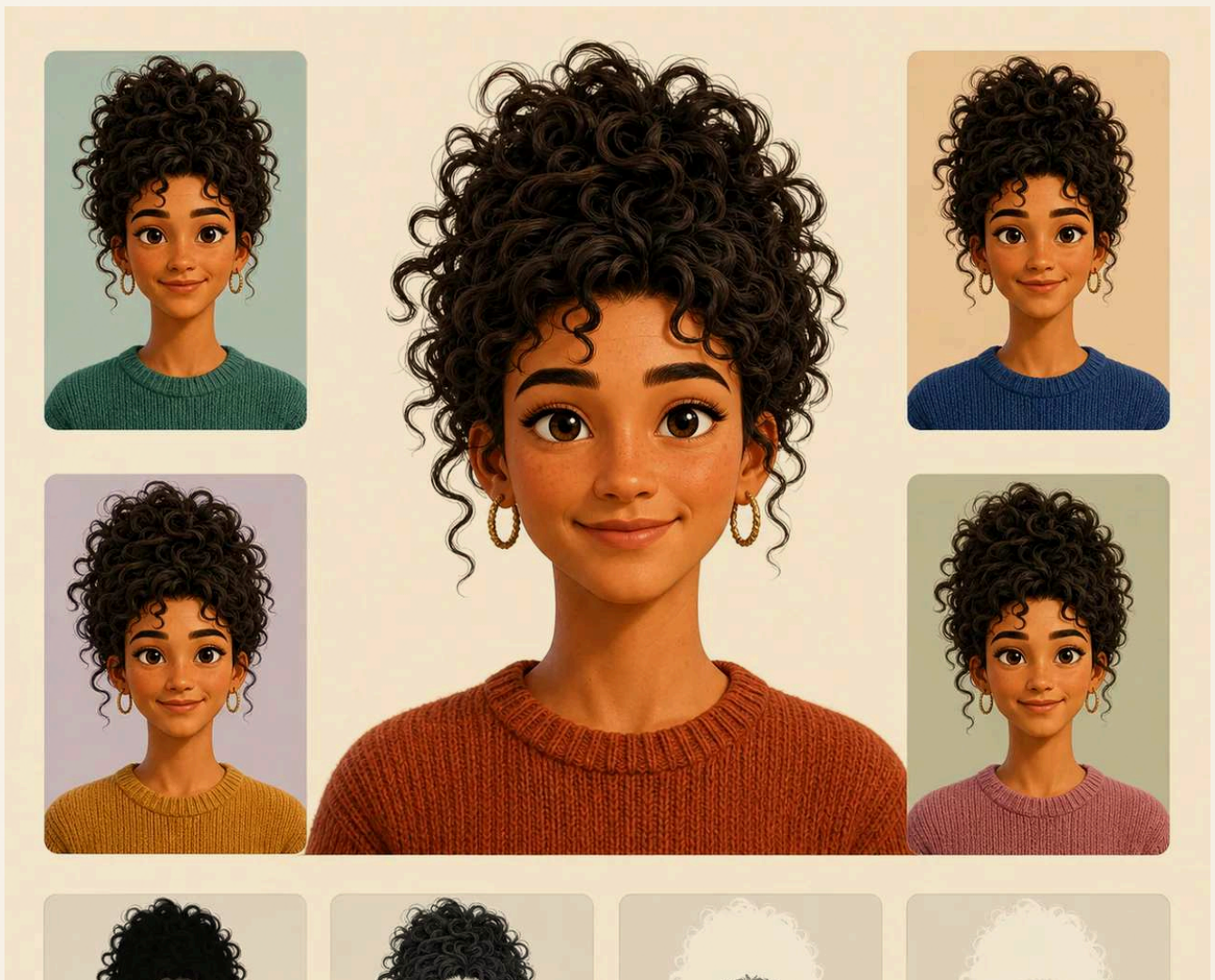
3D checkpoint

The model should preserve the approved portrait language.

- Turnaround is identity-consistent
- Topology supports lids, cheeks, lips, jaw, and neck
- Hair retains grouped masses
- Materials match the soft studio world
- Neutral, smile, blink, and speech shapes preserve identity

Production and QA

Only two layers change: background and upper garment.



Protect the person

Hair, face, neck, accessories, pose, texture, lighting, and identity remain unchanged.

Reviewed hair is a hard preservation layer. The reviewed shirt mask is garment authority. Fine matting may improve edges but must never turn protected hair or skin into garment or background.



Recolor locally

Generate a reusable mask once; never call an AI service when a color control moves.

Test extreme background and garment pairs. Confirm that the background reaches fine hair edges, the full garment changes, skin remains untouched, and texture survives.



Final acceptance

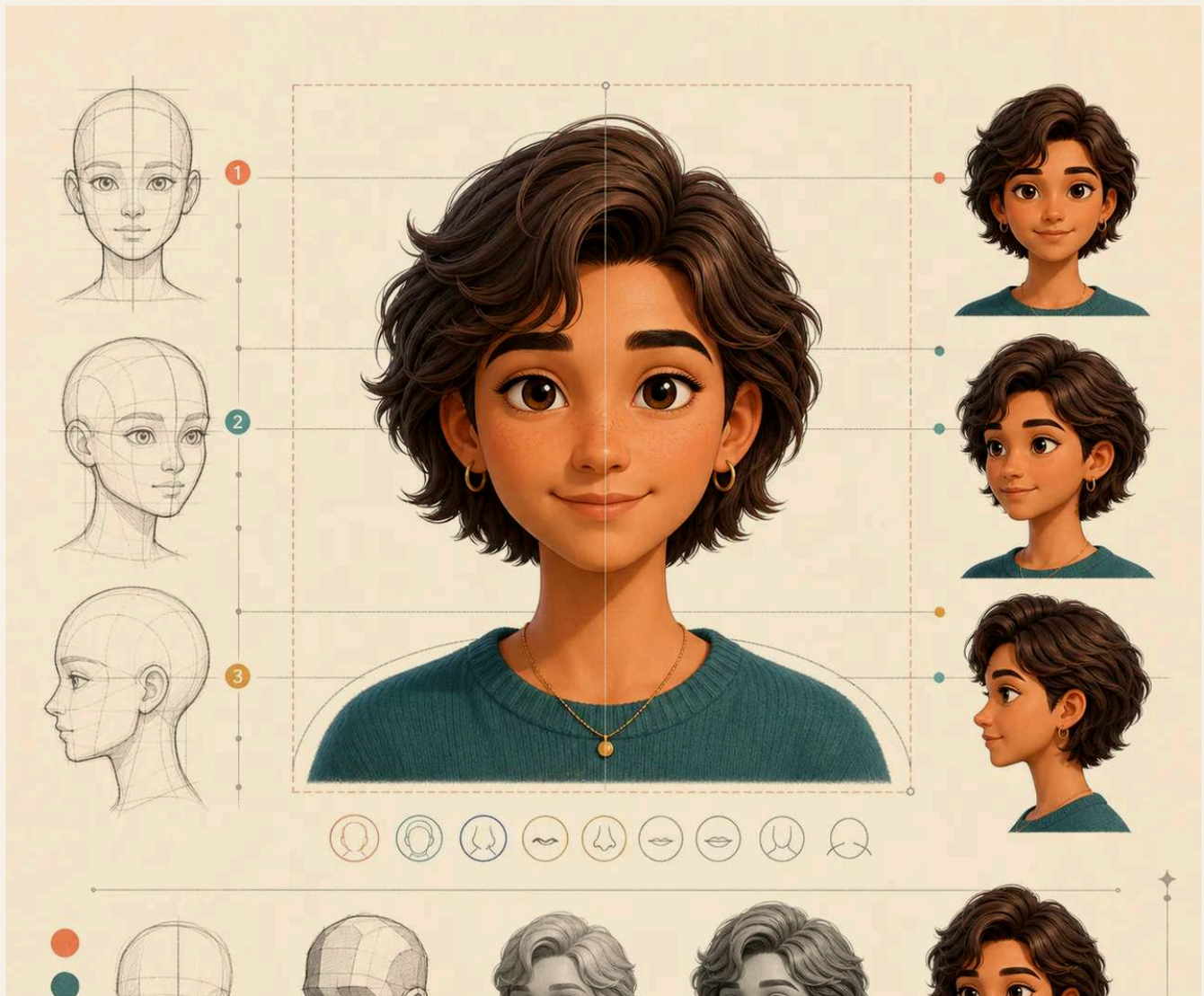
Review difficult portraits, not only the easiest one.

- Long dark hair over shoulders
- Hair and shirt with similar colors
- Warm skin with red or orange garment
- Head covering or prominent accessory
- Curly or flyaway hair
- Exact 1024 × 1024 export

Build a Palari

A compact artist workflow.

- Block frame, skull, neck, and shoulders
- Establish distinct face construction
- Solve gaze and expression together
- Add hair or headwear as designed masses
- Construct garment and accessories
- Paint clean local colors
- Add soft dimensional light
- Simplify noise and test color changes



Glossary

A shared vocabulary keeps review precise.

- Primary mass — the largest readable form
- Secondary clump — a mid-size rhythm inside a mass
- Local color — the base color before lighting
- Matte — a grayscale coverage layer
- Authority mask — the reviewed production boundary
- Framing transform — one shared scale and center adjustment

References

Further study in character design and publishing.

- Toon Boom Learn — Character Model Sheets
- 3dtotal Publishing — Fundamentals of Character Design
- Character Design Quarterly — Sample Issue 2026
- Tom Bancroft — Creating Characters with Personality
- Stephen Silver — The Silver Way
- Chronicle Books — The Art of Pixar
- Adobe InDesign — Creating Book Files

Made with care

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